

HOMER

THE ILIAD

Complete provisional interior architecture proof

7 x 10 inch hardcover / 80# coated paper target

Translation status: first-pass draft; Greek-fidelity and editorial gates remain open.

BOOK I

First-pass working translation

Sing, goddess, of the wrath of Peleus' son Achilles,
the ruinous wrath that brought unnumbered grief
upon the Achaeans, and sent many brave souls
before their time into the house of Hades,
making their bodies prey for dogs and every bird—
while Zeus's will was brought toward fulfillment—
from that first hour when Atreus' son, the king
of men, and godlike Achilles stood at odds.
Who, then, among the gods joined them in strife?
The son of Leto and of Zeus. For he,
angered against the king, sent through the host
a deadly plague; and the people perished,
because Agamemnon had dishonored Chryses,
the priest, who came before the swift ships,
to ransom his dear daughter, bearing gifts
beyond all measure, and in his hands the wreath
and golden staff of far-darting Apollo;
he prayed to all the Achaeans, but most of all
to Atreus' sons, the marshals of the people.
The priest came then to the shore, and prayed to Apollo,
the lord who bears the silver bow, and called upon him:
“Hear me, you of the fair hair, you who keep Chryse
and holy Cilla, and who rule Tenedos in power;
if ever I have built you a pleasing temple,
or burned for you the rich thigh-pieces of bulls
and goats, grant this desire: let the Danaans pay
for my tears beneath your arrows.” So he prayed,
and Phoebus Apollo heard him. Down from Olympus
he came, his heart full of anger, carrying his bow
and covered quiver. The arrows rang upon his shoulder
as the god moved; and he sat apart from the ships,
then loosed a shaft. First the mules and swift hounds
he struck; afterward he turned his bitter arrows

against the men. Through all the camp the pyres
 burned without rest.
 For nine days the shafts of the god went forth.
 On the tenth, Achilles called the people to assembly.
 Hera of the white arms had put the thought within him,
 grieving for the Danaans as she watched them perish.
 When they had gathered, Achilles rose among them:
 “Son of Atreus, soon we shall be driven back again,
 wandering among the waves, if any man remains alive.
 Come, let us ask a seer, or priest, or interpreter
 of dreams—for dreams are also from Zeus—to tell us
 why Phoebus is so bitter, whether he blames our vows
 or hecatombs, and whether he might meet us again
 and ward the ruin off by the savor of lambs
 and goats made perfect in sacrifice.”
 He sat, and Calchas rose among them, Thestor's son,
 the best of augurs, who knew what is, what was, and what will be,
 and who had led the Achaean ships to Ilium
 by that prophetic art Apollo gave to him.
 With thoughtful speech he answered them and said:
 “Achilles, dear to Zeus, you ask me to declare
 the wrath of Apollo, lord of the far-shooting bow.
 I will speak it;
 but swear to stand beside me, and be ready in word
 and hand. For I think that man
 will soon be angered against me, the one who rules
 the Argives, and whose word the army must obey.
 No light thing is a king's resentment; stronger
 is a king when angered against a lesser man. If he hides
 his anger for a day, it grows and waits for payment.”
 Achilles answered him: “Speak freely. No one here,
 while I draw breath and look upon the light of day,
 shall lift a hand against you—not Agamemnon,
 though he names himself the greatest of the Greeks.”
 Then the blameless seer took courage and spoke:
 “No vow, no hecatomb, no offering is lacking.
 The god's wrath is for Chryses and his daughter,

whom Agamemnon will not release. Send her home,
 without a price or ransom; sacrifice at Chryse.
 Then the god may turn from us and end the plague.”
 He finished. Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 rose in anger. His dark heart filled with shadow:
 “Prophet of evil, never have you spoken good to me.
 You love to tell the army what will bring it sorrow;
 you have not once announced a thing accomplished.
 Now for the girl: I will give her back, if that is best.
 But bring me another prize at once, lest I alone
 among the Argives go without honor.”
 Agamemnon, anger still black around his heart,
 rose and spoke to Calchas first:
 “Prophet of evil, never have you spoken good to me.
 You love to prophesy what brings the army sorrow;
 you have never spoken a good word or brought it to pass.
 And now among the Danaans you declare that the far-shooter
 deals them pain because I would not accept the shining ransom
 for Chryseis, because I desired to keep her in my house.
 I prefer her even to Clytemnestra, my wedded wife;
 she is not less than Clytemnestra in form, in stature,
 in mind, or in the work of her hands. Still, I will give her back,
 if that is better. I would rather keep my people safe than see them die.
 But make ready another prize for me at once, so that I alone
 among the Argives do not go without my honor—you all see
 that my prize is being carried elsewhere.”
 Achilles, swift of foot, looked at him darkly and answered:
 “Son of Atreus, most glorious and most greedy of all men,
 how shall the great-hearted Achaeans give you a prize?
 We know of no common stores lying in abundance here:
 the spoils from the cities we took have been divided,
 and it would not be fitting to gather the people together
 and make them give those portions back. Send this girl
 to the god now; and when we take Troy's well-built city,
 we shall pay you three and four times over, if Zeus grants it.”
 Agamemnon, king of men, replied:
 “Do not, godlike Achilles, though you are good, hide your thought

and try to deceive me; you will not slip past me or persuade me.
Do you want to keep your own prize while I sit here without one,
and command me to give this girl away? If the great-hearted Achaeans
give me a prize, making it fit my desire, so be it. But if they do not,
I myself will take one—yours, Ajax's, or Odysseus's—and carry it away.
The man I visit will be angry; we shall settle that another time.
For now, haul the black ship down to the shining sea,
gather rowers in proper number, put the hecatomb aboard,
and send fair-cheeked Chryseis. Let one of the counselors lead:
Ajax, Idomeneus, godlike Odysseus—or you, son of Peleus,
most terrible of men—so that you may appease the far-shooter
by performing the holy rites.”

Achilles, looking darkly at him, answered:

“Ah, clothed in shamelessness and bent on gain—who among the Achaeans
will follow you freely, whether to march or fight in battle?

I did not come here to fight the spear-famed Trojans for my own sake:
they have never wronged me. They never drove off my cattle or my horses;
they never in Phthia, rich in soil and men, destroyed my harvest—
there are shadowed mountains and the sounding sea between us.

No: we followed you, great shameless one, to win honor for Menelaus
and for you, dog-face, from the Trojans—though you neither notice nor care.
And now you threaten to take from me the prize for which I labored,
which the sons of the Achaeans gave me. I never receive a prize equal to yours
when the Achaeans sack a well-inhabited Trojan city;
my hands bear the greater burden of the furious war.

But when the division comes, your prize is far larger,
while I carry a small but cherished portion to my ships,
after I have grown weary fighting. Now I will go to Phthia:
it is far better to sail home in my curved ships
than to remain here dishonored and heap up wealth and treasure for you.”

“Go, then, if your heart urges you; I do not beg you to stay for my sake.

There are others here who will honor me, and Zeus above all,
the counselor. You are the most hateful of the kings he nourishes.

Strife, wars, and battles are always dear to you.

If you are mighty, some god has given you that gift.

Go home with your ships and companions, rule your Myrmidons;

I care nothing for your wrath, nor do I count it as a threat.

But this I tell you: as Phoebus Apollo takes Chryseis from me,
I will send her away in my ship with my companions;
then I myself will go to your hut and take fair-cheeked Briseis,
your prize, so that you may know how much stronger I am than you,
and that every other man may fear to call himself my equal.”
Then grief and anger gathered in Achilles' chest.
He weighed two thoughts: to draw his sword from his thigh
and scatter the assembly, or to master his heart and endure.
As he drew the great blade, Athena came down from heaven,
sent by the white-armed goddess Hera, who loved both men.
She stood behind him, visible to him alone, and caught his hair.
Achilles turned and said: “Why have you come, child of Zeus?
To watch the insolence of Agamemnon? I tell you this:
his life, I think, will soon pay for what he has done.”
The goddess of flashing eyes answered him:
“I came to restrain you. Put away the sword.
Speak against him as fiercely as you will, but do not strike.
One day, for this dishonor, gifts three times over
will be set before you. Hold your hand and obey.”
Achilles answered: “A man must obey you, goddess,
though anger burns. It is better so. Whoever obeys the gods,
the gods hear him in return.” He drove the blade back
into its sheath, and Athena rose again to Olympus.
Then he faced the son of Atreus and spoke once more:
“You who wear a dog's eyes and carry a deer's heart,
never do you arm with the people for battle,
never go with the best into an ambush or the line.
That would be death to you. It is easier to walk the camp
and strip a man of his prize. You rule men who obey you,
because you are a king who feeds upon his own people.
Otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage.
But I swear a great oath: by this staff, which will never again
put forth leaf or branch, since bronze cut it from the mountain
and stripped its bark, and now judges carry it in their hands,
judges who keep the laws that come from Zeus—
so surely shall a day come when all the Achaeans
will long for Achilles. Then, though you suffer, you cannot help them,

when Hector, breaker of ranks, kills men beside their ships.
You will tear your heart for the champion you dishonored.”
He flung the gold-studded staff upon the ground and sat.
Across from him Agamemnon still raged. But Nestor rose,
the clear-speaking elder from Pylos, whose tongue flowed sweeter
than honey. Two generations of mortal men had passed before him,
and now he ruled among the third. He addressed them:
“What sorrow has come upon the Achaean land!
The Trojans would rejoice, and Priam’s sons, and all the rest,
if they could hear you. End this quarrel. You are both younger
than I, and I have stood beside men greater than you.
Yet they listened when I spoke, and followed my counsel.
Listen now. You, Agamemnon, do not take the girl;
let her remain. And you, Achilles, do not contend
with the king, since no other scepter-bearing man
has honor equal to his. If you are the stronger, still he is greater
in rank, and more men obey him.”
Achilles cut him off: “No coward would endure your words.
Let others take your commands; do not command me:
I do not think I shall obey you any longer. And mark this well:
I will not fight you with my hands for the girl’s sake,
nor you, nor any other man, since you have taken her from me.
But of all the other things I have beside my swift black ship,
you shall carry off none against my will. Come—try it,
so that these men may see: your black blood will run around my spear.”
They broke the assembly. Achilles went to his ships
with Patroclus and his companions. Agamemnon hauled a swift ship
down to the sea, chose twenty rowers, and put aboard
the hecatomb for the god. He led fair-cheeked Chryseis aboard,
and set wise Odysseus as captain. They climbed in and sailed
the wet roads of the sea; meanwhile Agamemnon ordered the army
to cleanse itself. They washed and cast the filth into the sea,
then sacrificed perfect hecatombs of bulls and goats to Apollo
beside the shore of the barren sea; the smoke curled upward to heaven.
But the king did not cease from the quarrel he had first threatened.
He called Talthybius and Eurybates, his heralds and eager servants:
“Go to the hut of Achilles, son of Peleus; take fair-cheeked Briseis

by the hand and lead her here. If he will not give her, I myself will come with more men and take her—and that will be worse for him.”

They went unwillingly along the barren shore and came to the huts and ships of the Myrmidons. They found Achilles sitting beside his hut and black ship. He was not glad to see them. They stood, afraid and ashamed before the king, and said nothing.

Achilles knew why they had come and spoke first:

“Hail, heralds, messengers of Zeus and of men. Come nearer.

You are not to blame; Agamemnon is to blame, who sent you for the girl. Patroclus, beloved companion, bring her out and give her to them. Let these two be witnesses before the blessed gods, before mortal men, and before the harsh king himself, if ever again there is need of me to ward disgraceful death from the others.

For he sacrifices with a mind bent on destruction; he does not know how to think at once of what is before him and what is behind, so that the Achaeans beside the ships might fight in safety.”

Patroclus obeyed his beloved companion. He led fair-cheeked Briseis from the hut and gave her to the heralds, who returned to the Achaean ships.

The woman went unwillingly. Achilles sat apart from his companions, weeping, on the shore of the gray sea, and looked out across the boundless water. He stretched both hands toward his dear mother and prayed:

“Mother, since you bore me though I was doomed to a short life, at least Olympian Zeus, the high-thundering one, should have granted me honor; but now he has honored me not even a little. Agamemnon, son of Atreus, wide-ruling, has dishonored me: he has taken my prize, and keeps it for himself.”

His mother heard him from the depths of the sea, seated beside her old father.

Swiftly she rose from the gray sea like a mist, sat before her weeping son, caressed him with her hand, and called him by name:

“Child, why do you weep? What grief has come into your heart?

Speak out; do not hide it within you. Let us both know.”

With a heavy groan Achilles answered:

“You know it. Why should I tell it all to you, who know it already?

We went to sacred Thebes, the city of Eetion; we sacked it and brought everything here. The sons of the Achaeans divided it fairly among themselves, but they chose fair-cheeked Chryseis for Agamemnon.

Then Chryses, priest of far-darting Apollo, came to the swift ships

of the bronze-clad Achaeans to ransom his daughter, bringing
immeasurable gifts and holding in his hands the wreath and golden staff
of the far-shooting god. He begged all the Achaeans,
and above all the two sons of Atreus, commanders of the people.
All the other Achaeans approved: they urged reverence for the priest
and acceptance of the shining ransom. But Agamemnon's heart did not consent;
he sent the old man away harshly and laid a strong command upon him.
The old man went back in anger, and Apollo heard his prayer,
for he loved him dearly. He shot a deadly arrow among the Argives,
and the people died one after another as the god's shafts moved everywhere
through the wide camp of the Achaeans. Then the prophet who knew the god's will
spoke among us. I was the first to order that the god be appeased.
But anger seized the son of Atreus; he rose at once and threatened me—
and the threat is now fulfilled. The Achaeans are sending Chryseis
to Chryse in the swift ship, with gifts for the lord;
and heralds have just taken from my hut Briseis,
the girl the sons of the Achaeans gave me. Now, if you can,
protect your son: go to Olympus and supplicate Zeus. If ever
you helped his heart by word or deed—for many times in my father's house
I heard you boast that you alone among the immortals saved the dark-clouded
son of Cronus from disgrace, when Hera, Poseidon, and Athena
wanted to bind him. You came and loosed him, goddess,
quickly calling to high Olympus the Hundred-Handed One,
whom the gods call Briareus and men Aegaeon, stronger even than his father;
he sat beside the son of Cronus in glory, and the blessed gods feared him
and did not bind Zeus. Remind him of this, sit beside him, and clasp his knees,
if he will somehow help the Trojans, drive the Achaeans back to their ships
and the sea, and let them be cut down, so that all may profit by their king;
so that Agamemnon may learn what madness he committed when he dishonored
the best of the Achaeans.”

Thetis answered him, weeping:

“Ah, my child, why did I raise you, bearing such bitter grief?

Would that you could sit beside the ships without tears and without pain,
since your portion of life is short and not long at all.

But now you are short-lived and more miserable than all men;

for an evil destiny I bore you in my halls. I will go myself

to Olympus, to Zeus who delights in thunder, and tell him these things,

to see if he will listen. But for now sit beside your swift ships,
hold your wrath against the Achaeans, and withdraw altogether from war.
For Zeus went yesterday to Ocean and the blameless Ethiopians to feast,
and all the gods went with him. On the twelfth day he will return to Olympus;
then I will go to his bronze-floored house, clasp his knees,
and I think I shall persuade him.”

Meanwhile Odysseus reached sacred Chryse,
bringing the holy hecatomb. When they entered the deep harbor,
they furled the sails, laid them in the black ship,
lowered the mast into its rest, and rowed swiftly to anchorage.
They cast out the anchors and made fast the stern-lines;
then they stepped ashore through the breakers,
and brought out the hecatomb for the far-shooting god.
Chryseis too came down from the seafaring ship.
Wise Odysseus led her to the altar, placed her in her dear father's hands,
and spoke: “Chryses, Agamemnon, king of men, sent me
to bring your child and sacrifice this holy hecatomb to Phoebus
for the Danaans, so that we may appease the lord
who has brought such grievous sorrows upon the Argives.”
He placed her in her father's hands, and the old man received his child
with joy. The Achaeans then set the well-built hecatomb
around the altar of the far-shooter, washed their hands,
and lifted the barley for the rite. Chryses prayed aloud,
his hands raised to heaven:

“Hear me, god of the silver bow, who guard Chryse,
holy Cilla, and rule Tenedos in strength.
You heard me before when I prayed; you honored me
and struck the Achaean people with a great blow.
Grant me this wish once more: defend the Danaans now
from their shameful plague.”

So he prayed, and Phoebus Apollo heard him.
When they had prayed and scattered the barley, they drew back the heads,
cut the throats, flayed the victims, and cut out the thighs.
They wrapped them in fat, laid raw flesh upon them,
and the old man burned them on split wood, pouring bright wine over them;
young men stood beside him with five-pronged forks in their hands.
When the thighs had burned and they had tasted the inward parts,

they cut the rest into pieces, pierced it on spits,
roasted it carefully, and drew all the meat away.
When the work was finished and the feast prepared,
they ate, and no man's heart lacked an equal portion.
When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, the young men filled the mixing bowls,
and poured the wine into every cup, beginning on the right.
All day the young Achaeans appeased the god with song,
singing the beautiful paean and praising the far-shooter;
and he rejoiced to hear them.
When the sun had set and darkness came, they slept beside the ship.
When rose the early-born, rosy-fingered Dawn,
they sailed back toward the wide Achaean camp.
The far-shooter sent them a fair wind. They raised the mast,
spread the white sails, and the wind filled the middle canvas.
The purple wave roared around the speeding ship's stern,
and she ran across the sea, cutting her road through the water.
When they reached the broad camp of the Achaeans,
they hauled the black ship high upon the mainland sand,
set long props beneath it, and scattered to their huts and ships.
But godlike Achilles, swift of foot, remained beside his swift ships,
holding his wrath. He never went to the assembly that brings men glory,
never went out to battle; his dear heart wasted where he sat,
longing for the battle-cry and the war.
When the twelfth dawn had appeared, all the everlasting gods
went together to Olympus, with Zeus leading them.
Thetis did not forget her son's command. She rose from the sea
and climbed like mist through the great heavens to Olympus.
She found the wide-seeing son of Cronus sitting apart from the others
on the highest peak of many-ridged Olympus. She sat before him,
clasped his knees with her left hand, touched his chin with her right,
and supplicated Zeus, the son of Cronus:
"Father Zeus, if ever among the immortals I helped you
by word or deed, fulfill this wish for me.
Honor my son, who is doomed to die before all others.
Agamemnon, king of men, has dishonored him;
he took his prize and keeps it for himself.
But honor him, Olympian Zeus, counselor of the gods;

give the Trojans strength until the Achaeans honor my son
and increase his standing.”

She spoke. Zeus, gatherer of clouds, did not answer.

He sat long in silence. Thetis held fast to his knees
and asked him once more:

“Give me an unfailing promise and incline your head,
or refuse me—there is no fear in you—so I may know
how utterly I am dishonored among the gods.”

Zeus groaned heavily and answered:

“Ah, what a difficult task you set me: Hera will quarrel with me
when she taunts me with reproachful words.

Even without this, she is always scolding me before the immortals,
and says that I aid the Trojans in battle.

Go back now, before Hera notices. I will remember this
and bring it to fulfillment. To make you trust me,

I will nod with my head; there is no greater sign among the immortals.

What I confirm with a nod cannot be revoked, denied,
or left unfulfilled.”

The son of Cronus bent his dark brows and nodded.

His immortal hair streamed forward from his head,
and he shook great Olympus beneath him.

So they took counsel and parted. Thetis plunged into the deep sea
from bright Olympus, while Zeus went to his own house.

All the gods rose from their seats together when their father approached;
none dared remain seated to meet him.

Hera of the white arms had not failed to see him. She knew
that the silver-footed Thetis, daughter of the old man of the sea,
had shared his counsels. At once she spoke with taunting words:

“Who was it now, crafty one, who shared your secret counsel?

You always love to think in secret, apart from me,
and never willingly tell me what you have decided.”

The father of gods and men answered her:

“Hera, do not hope to know all my thoughts.

They will be difficult for you, though you are my wife.

No one else, god or man, will learn first the thought
that I wish to keep apart from everyone.”

Ox-eyed, revered Hera answered:

“Most terrible son of Cronus, what have you said?
I neither ask you nor question you; sit quietly and think
whatever you wish. But I fear terribly that silver-footed Thetis,
daughter of the old man of the sea, came to you at dawn,
sat beside you, and clasped your knees.
I think you promised her truly to honor Achilles
and destroy many Achaeans beside their ships.”
Zeus, gatherer of clouds, answered:
“Strange one, you are always thinking and never escape my notice.
Yet you will accomplish nothing; you will only become farther from my heart.
And that will be worse for you. Sit down in silence and obey my word,
lest all the gods on Olympus fail to help you when I stretch
my invincible hands against you.”
Hera fell silent, afraid, and sat with her heart subdued.
The heavenly gods within Zeus's house were troubled.
Then Hephaestus, famous for his craft, rose to speak,
bringing comfort to his dear, white-armed mother:
“This will be a disastrous and unbearable thing
if you two quarrel so over mortal men,
and bring disorder among the gods. There will be no joy
in the good feast, because the worse thing has prevailed.
I urge my mother—and she knows this herself—to bring comfort
to our dear father Zeus, so that he will not scold her again
and disturb our feast.”
He leapt up and placed a beautiful double cup
in his mother's hands, and spoke again:
“Endure, my mother, and bear it, though you love me dearly,
lest I see you struck before my eyes and be unable to help you.
It is hard to stand against the Olympian. Once before,
when I came eager to defend you, he seized me by the foot
and hurled me from the threshold of heaven.
All day I fell, and at sunset I landed in Lemnos,
with little life remaining. There the Sintian men cared for me at once.”
He spoke, and the white-armed goddess Hera smiled,
smiling, she accepted the cup from her son's hand.
He poured sweet nectar for all the other gods in turn,
drawing it from the mixing bowl. Unquenchable laughter rose

among the blessed gods when they saw Hephaestus bustling through the hall.
So they feasted all day until the sun went down,
and no heart lacked its equal portion—not Apollo's beautiful lyre,
nor the Muses' lovely answering song.
When the sun's bright light had set, each god went to his own house,
where famous, lame-footed Hephaestus had built a dwelling
with his knowing mind. Zeus, Olympian lord of the thunderbolt,
went to the bed where he had slept before whenever sweet sleep came upon him.
He climbed into it and slept; beside him lay Hera of the golden throne.

Source range: Book 1. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 2

First-pass working translation

When the other gods and the armed men had slept
through the dark night, Zeus who gathers clouds kept wake.
He thought how he might honor Achilles, and bring
the Achaeans to destruction beside their ships.
At last he found the counsel best: send a false dream
to Agamemnon, son of Atreus, king of men.
He called the Dream, and spoke with winged words:
“Go now, deceptive Dream, and stand beside the bed
of Agamemnon, in the likeness of old Nestor,
who is most trusted by the king. Tell him every word
as I command. Say: ‘Arm all the long-haired Achaeans.
Now you may take the city of broad-streeted Troy.
The gods who hold Olympus no longer disagree;
Hera has persuaded them, and ruin hangs above the Trojans.’”
So he spoke, and the Dream went swiftly on its errand.
It stood above the king's head, and took the likeness
of Nestor, who spoke to him in sleep:
“Son of Atreus, do you sleep? It is not right for a man
who bears the cares of armies to lie awake no longer.
Zeus has sent me to say that the gods are now united;
though he is far away, he cares for you and takes pity on you.
He commands you to arm the Achaeans without delay.
You will take wide-wayed Troy. Do not let the message
escape your mind when sweet sleep has released you.”
The Dream withdrew, leaving him to cherish in his heart
the thoughts it had planted—thoughts that were never to be fulfilled.
He thought the immortal voice had spoken truth,
not knowing what Zeus had devised, and that on that very day
he would take Priam's city. He did not know what the son of Cronus
was still preparing: more pain and groaning for Trojans and Danaans
through the violence of battle.
and rose at once, putting on his soft wool tunic.
Over it he threw a great cloak, and bound beneath his feet

his shining sandals. Then he slung the silver-studded sword
across his shoulders, and took the scepter of his fathers,
imperishable, with which he went among the Achaeans.
When Dawn, the goddess, climbed high Olympus
to announce the light to Zeus and the other immortals,
he first called the heralds, clear-voiced men,
to summon the long-haired Achaeans to assembly.
They called, and the people gathered swiftly.
First Agamemnon summoned the council of the great-hearted elders
beside Nestor's ship, and made his careful plan:
“Friends, a divine dream came to me through the ambrosial night.
It looked most like Nestor in form, size, and stature;
it stood above my head and spoke: ‘Do you sleep, son of Atreus?
It is not right for a counselor, with peoples entrusted to him,
to sleep all night. Listen quickly: I am a messenger of Zeus,
who, though he is far away, cares greatly for you and pities you.
He commands you to arm the long-haired Achaeans at once.
Now you might take broad-wayed Troy, for the immortals who dwell
in Olympus no longer deliberate apart: Hera has bent them all,
and grief hangs over the Trojans by Zeus's will.’
So it spoke and flew away, and sweet sleep released me.
Come now, if we can, let us arm the sons of the Achaeans.
First I will test them with words, as custom allows,
and order them to flee with their many-oared ships;
you must hold them back, each man speaking from his place.”
He sat, and Nestor, king of sandy Pylos, answered:
“If another Achaean had told us of this dream,
we would call it false and urge a stronger flight.
But the man who claims to be the greatest of the Achaeans
saw it. Come, let us arm the sons of the Achaeans.”
So he spoke, and the council rose and obeyed the shepherd of the people.
As bees stream from a hollow rock in endless clusters,
when spring flowers open across the field,
and some fly in a cloud while others settle in the meadow—
so the many tribes of the Achaeans came from ships and shelters,
filing before the deep shore into assembly.
Rumor, Zeus's messenger, burned among them and urged them forward.

The gathering roared, the earth groaned beneath the seated people,
 and nine heralds shouted until they could quiet the noise enough
 for the god-nourished kings to be heard. The people sat in haste,
 and the clamor ceased. Agamemnon rose, holding the scepter
 that Hephaestus made and gave to Zeus, and Zeus to Hermes,
 the messenger who slays Argus; Hermes gave it to Pelops,
 the horse-driving king; Pelops left it to Atreus, shepherd of the people,
 and dying Atreus left it to Thyestes, rich in flocks;
 Thyestes left it to Agamemnon to carry, that he might rule
 over many islands and all Argos. Leaning upon it, he spoke:
 “Friends, heroes, Danaans, servants of Ares, Zeus the son of Cronus
 has bound me in a great and ruinous delusion—cruel Zeus,
 who once promised and nodded that I would return after sacking
 well-built Ilium, but now has devised a wicked deception
 and commands me to return to Argos without glory,
 having lost so many people. So, it seems, it pleases mighty Zeus,
 who has destroyed the crowns of many cities and will destroy more:
 his power is greatest. It would be shameful for those yet unborn
 to hear that we, so many, fought an unprofitable war
 against fewer men and never reached its end.
 If Achaeans and Trojans were counted under a faithful truce,
 if the Trojans gathered all who live within their city,
 and we Achaeans were arranged in tens, each ten choosing a Trojan
 to pour the wine, many tens of us would still lack a cupbearer:
 so much greater, I say, is our number than theirs.
 But allies from many cities stand beside them, spear-bearing men,
 who keep me from taking the well-inhabited city of Ilium.
 Nine years of great Zeus have already passed;
 the timbers of our ships have rotted and the rigging has slackened.
 Our wives and little children sit at home awaiting us,
 while our work here remains unfinished, for which we came.
 Come now, let us all obey what I say: let us flee in our ships
 to our dear fatherland. We shall never take broad-wayed Troy.”
 So he spoke, and stirred the hearts of all those who had not heard
 the council. The assembly moved like the long waves of the Icarian Sea,
 when East and South leap upon them from the clouds of Father Zeus;
 or as when the West Wind comes upon a deep field of grain,

driving violently over the ears and bowing the standing corn.
The assembly broke. They surged toward the ships,
shouting like waves that the south wind drives upon a beach,
when a deep sea runs in beneath the open shore.
But Hera, who watched the Achaeans scatter, said to Athena:
“Daughter of Zeus, will the Argives leave this land,
and give the glory of Helen to Priam and his sons?
Go now among them, and hold each man in place.”
Athena went down through the crowd. She found Odysseus,
whose mind was equal to the gods, still standing by his scepter.
He did not touch a ship, nor prepare to flee.
She stood beside him and said: “Son of Laertes,
why do you run as though every man were rushing home?
Sit here, and let the others sit as well. The king's speech
was a test, not an order to abandon the war.”
Odysseus turned, and went among the men, taking the scepter
from any noble who held it. To a king he spoke with courtesy:
“It is not fitting for you to stand like a coward.
Sit and listen. Others will hear you later.”
But when he found a common man shouting, he struck him
with the scepter and rebuked him:
“Friend, stay quiet and listen to those who have greater honor.
You are weak in war, and weak in counsel. No one man
can rule us all. There must be one king.”
The people returned from the ships. The gathering became
like a high wave breaking, then settling in its bed.
Only Thersites remained, still pouring out his unmeasured words.
He knew many shameful things, but knew no order in his speech;
he loved to quarrel with kings and say whatever seemed laughable
to the Argives. He was the ugliest man who came to Ilium:
bandy-legged, lame in one foot, his shoulders hunched together
over his chest, and above them his pointed head was thinly covered
with down. Achilles and Odysseus hated him most of all,
for he was always abusing them. Now he shrilled against Agamemnon,
and the Achaeans grew angry and resented him in their hearts.
He shouted loudly and reproached the shepherd of the people:
“Son of Atreus, what are you blaming now, and what do you lack?

Your huts are full of bronze, and many women are there,
 chosen out for you first whenever we take a city.
 Do you still lack gold, some ransom a horse-taming Trojan
 will bring from Ilium for his son, whom I or another Achaean
 has bound and led away? Or a young woman, to join with her in love,
 whom you alone keep apart from the others? It is not fitting
 that the leader of our troubles should heap more trouble upon us.
 Soft, shameful Achaeans, no longer men—let us sail home
 with our ships and leave this man here in Troy to consume his prizes,
 so that he may see whether we are of any use to him or not—
 the man who has dishonored Achilles, a far better man than he,
 and taken his prize for himself. Yet Achilles is not angry enough;
 otherwise, son of Atreus, this would be your last outrage.”
 So Thersites mocked Agamemnon, shepherd of the people.
 At once godlike Odysseus stood beside him and looked him down:
 “Thersites, reckless speaker, hold your tongue. Do not try alone
 to quarrel with kings. I say there is no worse mortal than you
 among all who came with the sons of Atreus to Ilium.
 Therefore do not carry the kings' names in your mouth,
 or heap insults upon them, or urge the people home.
 We do not yet know how these matters will end,
 whether we Achaeans will return well or badly.
 You sit here abusing Agamemnon, shepherd of the people,
 because the heroes of the Danaans give him many gifts,
 and you speak by taunting. But I tell you—and this shall be fulfilled:
 if I find you raving again as now, let Odysseus have no head on his shoulders,
 and let me no longer be called Telemachus's father,
 if I do not strip your cloak and tunic, the garments that cover your shame,
 and send you weeping to the swift ships, beaten with disgraceful blows.”
 He struck his back and shoulders with the golden scepter.
 Thersites bent, tears fell thickly, and a bloody welt rose beneath the scepter.
 He sat trembling, wiped away the tear, and looked helplessly around.
 The army, though grieved for him, laughed aloud, and one man said to another:
 “Odysseus has done countless good things, leading counsel and arming war;
 but this is the best he has done among the Argives:
 he has stopped this abusive loudmouth from insulting kings.”
 So the multitude spoke. Then city-sacking Odysseus rose,

holding the scepter; beside him bright-eyed Athena,
in the likeness of a herald, ordered the people to be silent,
so that the first and last of the Achaeans might hear
and understand the counsel. Odysseus spoke thoughtfully:
“Son of Atreus, the Achaeans now want to make you,
their king, the most disgraced of all mortal men.
They do not fulfill the promise they made when they left Argos:
that they would return after taking well-built Ilium.
They groan like young children and widowed women,
each longing to go home. It is painful to stay and return
after a single month away from one's wife on a many-benched ship,
when winter winds and the troubled sea hold a man in place.
But we have spent nine turning years here; I do not blame
the Achaeans for grieving beside their curved ships.
Yet it is shameful to remain long and return empty-handed.
Endure, friends, and stay a little longer, until we learn
whether Calchas truly prophesies or not. We know this well,
and you are all witnesses who escaped the fate of death:
when the Achaean ships gathered at Aulis, carrying slaughter
to Priam and the Trojans, we sacrificed perfect hecatombs
beside the spring, under a beautiful plane tree where clear water ran.
There a great sign appeared. A red-backed, terrible serpent,
sent into the light by Zeus himself, darted from beneath the altar
and rushed to the plane tree. There were eight sparrow nestlings,
young chicks huddled beneath the leaves on the highest branch;
their mother was the ninth, who had hatched them.
The serpent ate them as they chirped pitifully;
the mother flew around mourning her dear young,
but the serpent seized her by the wing as she cried out.
When it had eaten the chicks and their mother, the god who showed it
made the serpent conspicuous, turning it to stone.
We stood astonished at what Zeus had done.
Then Calchas spoke among us, interpreting the omen:
‘Why are you silent, long-haired Achaeans? Mighty Zeus
has shown us this great sign, late in appearing but late to fulfill,
whose glory shall never die. As the serpent ate the eight chicks
and their mother, the ninth, so shall we fight here for nine years;

in the tenth we shall take the broad-wayed city.
 That is what he said, and now all is being fulfilled.
 Stay here, well-greaved Achaeans, until we take Priam's great city."
 He spoke, and the Argives shouted loudly; the ships roared terribly
 under the Achaeans' cry, praising godlike Odysseus.
 Then Gerenian Nestor, the horseman, spoke:
 "Shame on you—you speak like children, like infants
 who know nothing of the work of war. Where are our agreements
 and oaths now? Let our counsels and plans, our libations
 and right hands pledged in trust, burn in fire.
 We quarrel with words and find no remedy, though we have been here long.
 Agamemnon, hold the unbending counsel you had before
 and lead the Argives through the harsh battle.
 Let those who plan apart from the Achaeans wither, one or two at a time;
 their plan will not succeed. Before we return to Argos,
 we must learn whether the promise of Zeus who bears the aegis
 was false or not. For I say that mighty Cronus's son nodded
 on the day we boarded our swift ships, carrying death to Troy,
 showing favorable signs with lightning on our right.
 Let no one hurry home before he has slept beside a Trojan wife
 and taken vengeance for Helen's striving and groaning.
 If anyone still fiercely desires to go home, let him touch
 his black, well-benched ship, so that he may meet death and fate
 before the others. And you, king, plan well and listen to another word:
 sort the men by tribes and clans, Agamemnon,
 so clan may help clan and tribe may help tribe.
 If you do this and the Achaeans obey, you will know
 which leader is bad and which is good, and which common man is brave:
 they will fight in their own divisions. You will know too
 whether you will fail to take the city because of your men's weakness
 or because of their lack of knowledge in war."
 Agamemnon answered him:
 "Old man, you win the assembly again. If only Zeus the father,
 Athena, and Apollo would give me ten counselors such as you among the Achaeans,
 Priam's city would soon bow and be sacked beneath our hands.
 But Zeus, son of Cronus, has given me grief: he throws me into
 useless quarrels and disputes. Achilles and I fought over a girl,

and I began it in anger. If we ever agree in one counsel again,
 Troy's suffering will no longer be delayed, not even for a little.
 Now go to dinner, so that we may join battle.
 Let each man sharpen his spear well, set his shield well,
 feed his swift-footed horses well, and inspect his chariot carefully,
 so that all day we may be tested in hateful Ares.
 There will be no pause, not even for a little, unless night comes
 to divide the force of men. The shield-strap will sweat
 around the chest of one man, his hand will grow weary on the spear;
 another's horse will sweat as he strains the polished chariot.
 But whoever I see willingly lingering apart from battle
 beside the curved ships will not escape the dogs and birds."
 The Argives shouted loudly, like waves breaking upon a high shore
 when the South Wind rises and drives them against a projecting rock;
 the waves never leave it, whatever wind blows from this side or that.
 They rose, scattered among the ships, and kindled fires in the huts;
 each man sacrificed to the everlasting gods, praying to escape death
 and the labor of Ares. Agamemnon sacrificed a five-year-old, fat ox
 to mighty Zeus, and called the oldest and best of the Pan-Achaeans:
 Nestor first, then King Idomeneus; the two Ajaxes, then Tydeus's son,
 and sixth Odysseus, whose mind was equal to Zeus's.
 Menelaus came of his own accord, for he knew in his heart
 how his brother labored. They stood around the ox, lifted the barley,
 and Agamemnon prayed:
 "Most glorious and greatest Zeus, dark-clouded lord of the sky,
 let not the sun go down and darkness come before I cast
 the smoky roof of Priam's house upon its face and burn its doors
 with hostile fire, and tear Hector's shirt across his breast
 with bronze, while many of his companions fall around him
 face-first in the dust and bite the earth."
 So he prayed, but the son of Cronus did not grant his prayer;
 he accepted the sacrifice, but increased the labor without end.
 When they had prayed and scattered the barley, they drew back the heads,
 cut the throats and flayed the victim, then cut out the thighs,
 wrapped them in fat, and laid the raw flesh upon them.
 They burned these on leafless sticks over the fire,
 and held the inward parts above the flame. When the thighs were burned

and they had tasted the inward parts, they cut the rest into pieces,
pierced them on spits, roasted them carefully, and drew away the meat.
When the labor was finished and the feast prepared, they ate;
no man's heart lacked an equal portion.
When they had satisfied hunger and thirst, Gerenian Nestor, the horseman,
spoke first:
"Most glorious son of Atreus, king of men, let us no longer
keep speaking here or delay the work the god places in our hands.
Let the heralds summon the bronze-clad Achaeans and gather them by the ships;
we will go together through the broad army and awaken sharp Ares."
So he spoke, and Agamemnon did not disobey. At once he ordered
the clear-voiced heralds to proclaim battle and gather the long-haired Achaeans.
They called, and the people assembled swiftly. Around Agamemnon
the god-nourished kings rushed to their places, and with them went bright-eyed
Athena, bearing the precious, ageless, deathless aegis;
from it hung a hundred golden tassels, each worth a hundred oxen.
With it she flashed through the Achaean ranks, urging them forward,
and put an unwearied strength into every heart to fight and make war.
Then battle became sweeter to them than sailing home
in their hollow ships to their dear fatherland.
As a ruinous fire blazes through an immense forest on a mountain's crest,
and its light is seen from far away, so from the bronze of the advancing host
a light rose through the air and reached heaven.
As the many tribes of winged birds—geese, cranes, or long-necked swans—
fly here and there on the Asian meadow beside the streams of Cayster,
settling joyfully on their wings with clamor that rings across the meadow,
so the many tribes poured from ships and huts onto the Scamandrian plain.
The earth beneath their feet and horses thundered terribly.
They stood on the flowering Scamandrian plain, countless as leaves and flowers
that come in their season. As countless swarms of flies wander through
the shepherds' fold in spring, when milk drenches the pails,
so many long-haired Achaeans stood on the plain, eager to break the Trojans.
As goatherds easily sort wide flocks of goats after they mingle in the pasture,
so the leaders arranged them here and there for battle.
Agamemnon stood among them, like Zeus who delights in thunder
in eyes and head, like Ares in his belt, like Poseidon in his chest.
As a bull stands conspicuous above all the cattle gathered in a herd,

so Zeus made the son of Atreus conspicuous and foremost among the many heroes.

“Tell me now, Muses, who dwell in Olympian houses—
you are goddesses, present and knowing all things;
we hear only rumor and know nothing for ourselves—
who were the leaders and commanders of the Danaans?
I could not name the multitude or tell its number,
not if I had ten tongues and ten mouths, an unbreakable voice,
and a bronze heart within me, unless the Olympian Muses,
daughters of aegis-bearing Zeus, remembered all who came to Ilium.
I will tell the leaders of the ships and all the ships themselves.”

First came the Boeotians. Peneleus and Leitus led them,
Arcesilaus, Prothoenor, Clonius beside them—
men of Hyria, rocky Aulis, Schoenus, and Scolus,
of Eteon, Thespia, Graia, and broad Mycalessus,
of Harma, Eileision, Erythrae, and Eleon,
of Hyle, Peteon, Ocalea, and well-built Medeon,
of Copae, Eutresis, deep-rifted Thisbe,
of Coronea, grassy Haliartus, Plataea,
and Glisas; of lower Thebes, well built,
of holy Onchestus, Poseidon’s shining grove,
of vine-rich Arne, Mideia, sacred Nisa,
and Anthedon, at the world’s far edge.

Fifty ships came from them, and in each ship
one hundred and twenty young Boeotians embarked.
Aspledon and Minyan Orchomenos sent their people,
under Ascalaphus and Ialmenus, sons of Ares,
whom Astyoche, daughter of Actor, bore to the god—
the modest maiden had climbed to her upper room,
and the strong god lay with her in secret.

Thirty hollow ships marched behind them.
The Phocians were led by Schedius and Epistrophus,
sons of great-hearted Iphitus, Naubolus’ son;
they held Cyparissus, rocky Pytho, sacred Crisa,
Daulis, Panopeus, Anemoria, and Hyampolis,
the dwellers beside divine Cephissus,
and those who held Lilaea by the springs of Cephissus.
Forty black ships followed them. The Phocians formed

their ranks beside the Boeotians, on the left.
Ajax, swift son of Oileus, led the Locrians—
the lesser Ajax, not so great as Telamonian Ajax,
but much smaller, lightly armored, a little man;
yet with his spear he surpassed all Panhellenes
and Achaeans. His men held Cynus, Opus, Calliarus,
Bessa, Scarphe, lovely Augeia, Tarphe, and Thronium,
around the streams of Boagrius. Forty black ships
followed the Locrians, who live beyond holy Euboea.
The Abantes held Euboea, breathless for battle:
Chalcis, Eretria, vine-rich Histiaea, Cerinthus,
the sea-cliff city of Dios, Carystus, and Styra.
Elephenor, son of Chalcodon, led them,
great-hearted chief of the Abantes. Behind him came
the swift-haired spearmen, eager with ashwood lances
to break the corslets on their enemies' chests.
Forty black ships followed them.
Those who held Athens, the city well built,
the people of great-hearted Erechtheus—whom Athena,
daughter of Zeus, once raised, and the grain-giving earth
bore, then set within her rich temple in Athens,
where Athenian youths appease him with bulls and lambs
as the years turn—were led by Menestheus, son of Peteus.
No man on earth could equal him in ordering
horses and shielded men for battle; only Nestor,
older by birth, contended with him. Fifty black ships
followed. Ajax brought twelve from Salamis
and stationed them beside the Athenian ranks.
The men of Argos held Tiryns with its walls,
Hermione and Asine deep in their bay,
Troezene, Epidaurus thick with vines,
Ægina, Mases, and the Achaean shore.
Diomedes, strong in battle, led them,
with Sthenelus, beloved son of famous Capaneus,
and Euryalus, godlike, son of king Mecisteus,
son of Talaus. Diomedes led them all.
Eighty black ships followed.

The men of Mycenae, the well-built city, came too,
 of wealthy Corinth and well-built Cleonae,
 of Orneia, lovely Aretbyrea, and Sicyon,
 where Adrastus first reigned, and of Hyperesia,
 high Gonoessa, Pellene, Ægium, and the shore
 all along Aegialus, around broad Helice.
 Agamemnon, son of Atreus, led one hundred ships;
 with him came the most numerous and best of the people.
 He himself put on the flashing bronze and shone,
 conspicuous among the heroes, since he was best
 and led a people far more numerous than the rest.
 The men of hollow Lacedaemon came, of Pharis,
 Sparta, Messa, Bryseiae, lovely Augeiae,
 Amyclae, Helos, the city by the sea,
 Laas, and Oetylus. Menelaus, his brother,
 led them—strong in battle—with sixty ships.
 They formed apart; he went among them trusting
 his own courage, urging the war, for most of all
 his heart desired to avenge Helen's distress and tears.
 The Pylian people held Pylos and lovely Arene,
 Thryon at the ford of Alpheius, well-built Epi,
 Cyparisseis, Amphigenia, Pteleos, Helos, and Dorion,
 where the Muses met Thamyris the Thracian,
 coming from Oechalia, from Eurytus of Oechalia;
 he boasted that he would defeat the Muses themselves
 if they, the daughters of Zeus who bears the aegis,
 should sing. Angered, they blinded him and stripped him
 of his wondrous song, making him forget the lyre.
 Gerenian horseman Nestor led them; ninety hollow ships
 marched in his wake.
 The Arcadians held the steep mountain under Cyllene,
 by the tomb of Aepytus, where men fight at close quarters;
 Pheneus, many-sheeped Orchomenos, Ripe, Stratia,
 windy Enispe, Tegea, lovely Mantinea,
 Stympthalus, and Parrhasia. Agapenor, son of Ancaeus,
 led them in sixty ships. Agamemnon himself,
 son of Atreus, supplied the strong-benched vessels,

for the Arcadians knew nothing of the sea;
they embarked in them to cross the wine-dark water,
many Arcadian men in every ship, skilled in war.
The men of Buprasium and divine Elis inhabited
the land from Hyrmine to Myrsinus at its edge,
from the Olenian rock to Alesium enclosed within.
Four leaders held them; ten swift ships followed each,
and many Epeans embarked. Amphinachus and Thalpius
led two divisions, sons respectively of Cteatus and Eurytus,
the Actorian pair; mighty Diores, son of Amarynceus,
led the third, and godlike Polyxenus, son of Agasthenes,
son of Augeias, led the fourth.

From Dulichium and the sacred Echinades islands,
which lie beyond the sea opposite Elis, came the people.
Meges, equal to Ares, led them—son of Phyleus,
beloved of Zeus, the horseman. Phyleus had once left
Dulichium in anger with his father. Forty black ships
followed Meges.

Odysseus led the great-hearted Cephallenians,
who held Ithaca, forest-shaking Neritum,
rough Ægilipa, Zacynthus, Crocylea,
and Asteria, and who held the mainland opposite.
Odysseus, equal to Zeus in counsel, commanded them;
twelve red-cheeked ships followed.

Thoas, son of Andraemon, led the Aetolians.
They held Pleuron, Olenus, Pylenè, sea-near Chalcis,
and rocky Calydon. The sons of great Oeneus were gone,
and Oeneus himself was gone; blond Meleager had died.
So Thoas had been charged to rule all the Aetolians.
Forty black ships followed him.

Idomeneus, famous with the spear, led the Cretans.
They held Cnossus, well-walled Gortyna, Lyctus,
Miletus, bright Lycastus, Phaestus, and Rhytium,
well-inhabited cities, and all who held Crete,
the land of a hundred cities. Idomeneus led them.
Meriones, equal to Enyalios the slayer, stood beside him;
eighty black ships followed the Cretan leaders.

Tlepolemus, Heracles' tall and noble son,
 brought nine ships from Rhodes. The Rhodians lived
 in three divisions—Lindus, Ialysus, and shining Camirus.
 Tlepolemus, famous with the spear, was born to Heracles
 and Astyoche, whom Heracles brought from Ephyra,
 after sacking the cities of the god-reared people.
 When Tlepolemus had grown in his great house,
 he killed his father's aged maternal uncle, Licymnius,
 an offshoot of Ares. He built ships at once,
 gathered a great people, and fled across the sea,
 for Heracles' other sons and grandsons threatened him.
 After suffering much, he reached Rhodes, and settled there
 in three tribes; Zeus, lord of gods and men, loved them
 and poured great wealth upon them.
 Nireus brought three equal ships from Syme—
 Nireus, son of Aglaia and King Charopus,
 the fairest man to come beneath Ilium after Peleus' son;
 but he was weak, and few followed him.
 The men of Nisyros, Crapathus, Casus, and Cos,
 the city of Eurypylus, and the Calydnian islands,
 were led by Pheidippus and Antiphus, two sons
 of Thessalus, Heracles' royal son. Thirty hollow ships
 marched behind them.
 Those who held Pelasgian Argos—Alos, Alope, and Trachis,
 Phthia and lovely Hellas—were called Myrmidons,
 Hellenes, and Achaeans. Achilles led their fifty ships,
 but they did not remember the harsh battle: no one was there
 to lead them into line. Swift-footed, godlike Achilles lay
 beside the ships, angry over fair-haired Briseis,
 whom he had taken from Lyrnessus after much toil,
 when he sacked Lyrnessus and the walls of Thebes,
 and killed Mynes and Epistrophus, spear-famed sons
 of King Evenus, Selepius' son. There he lay in grief,
 but soon he would rise.
 Those who held Phylace, flowery Pyrasus, Demeter's precinct,
 Iton, mother of sheep, Antron by the sea, and meadowed Pteleon,
 were led by warlike Protesilaus while he lived;

now the black earth held him. His wife, tearing her cheeks,
 was left in Phylace, and his house stood unfinished:
 a Dardanian killed him as he leapt first from his ship.
 Nor were his people leaderless, though they longed for him;
 Podarces, son of Iphiclus, rich in sheep, led them,
 Protesilaus' own brother, younger by birth. Yet Protesilaus
 had been first and better. Forty black ships followed.
 Those who held Pherae beside Lake Boebe, Boebe, Glaphyrae,
 and well-built Iolcus were led by Eumelus, dear son of Admetus,
 whom Alcestis, fairest of Pelias' daughters, bore to Admetus.
 Eleven ships followed him.
 Those who held Methone, Thaumacia, Meliboea,
 and rough Olizon were led by Philoctetes,
 skilled with the bow, in seven ships; fifty oarsmen,
 skilled in war, embarked in each. But Philoctetes lay
 on Lemnos, suffering cruel pain from a deadly serpent's wound,
 where the sons of the Achaeans had left him. There he lay
 in anguish; soon the Argives by the ships would remember
 their lord Philoctetes. Nor were his men leaderless:
 Medon, Oileus' bastard son, whom Rhene bore to the sacker
 of cities, arranged them. Seven ships followed.
 Those who held Tricca, rocky Ithome, and Oechalia,
 the city of Eurytus of Oechalia, were led by the two sons
 of Asclepius, good physicians, Podalirius and Machaon.
 Thirty hollow ships followed. Those who held Ormenius,
 the spring of Hypereia, Asteria, and the white peaks
 of Titanus were led by Euryphylus, glorious son of Euaemon,
 in forty black ships.
 Those who held Argissa, Gyrtone, Orthe, Elone,
 and white Oloosson were led by city-sacker Polypoetes,
 son of Pirithous, whom immortal Zeus fathered through
 Hippodameia on the day the Lapiths punished the shaggy Centaurs
 and drove them from Pelion among the Aethices. With him came
 Leonteus, an offshoot of Ares, son of the great-hearted
 Coronus, son of Caeneus. Forty black ships followed.
 Guneus brought twenty-two ships from Cyphus;
 the warlike Enienes and Perrhaebians followed him,

those who made their homes around wintry Dodona,
 and those who worked beside lovely Titaresius,
 whose clear water runs to Peneius but never mingles with him—
 it flows above him like oil, for it is a branch of Styx's oath.
 Prothous, son of Tenthredon, led the Magnetes,
 who lived beside Peneius and forest-shaking Pelion.
 Swift Prothous commanded them; forty black ships followed.
 These were the leaders and lords of the Danaans. Now, Muse,
 tell me who among them was best—the men themselves and the horses
 that followed the sons of Atreus. The best horses were those
 of Eumelus, swift as birds, alike in age and color,
 mares whom Apollo of the silver bow had bred in Pieria,
 carrying the terror of Ares. Of men, Telamonian Ajax was best
 while Achilles nursed his anger—for Achilles was far better,
 and his were the horses that bore the blameless son of Peleus.
 But Achilles lay in his sea-going ships, angry with Agamemnon;
 his people played beside the water with discus, javelins, and bows,
 while the horses stood by their chariots grazing lotus and marsh celery.
 The chariots lay covered in the tents, and the men, longing for their
 war-loving leader, wandered through the camp and did not fight.
 They moved like a fire sweeping across the whole earth;
 the ground groaned beneath their feet, as when thunder-loving Zeus,
 angry at Typhoeus, lashes the earth around Arima, where they say
 Typhoeus has his bed. So the earth groaned beneath their feet,
 and they crossed the plain swiftly.
 Swift-footed Iris came to the Trojans as a messenger
 from Zeus who bears the aegis, carrying a grievous message.
 They were speaking in assembly at Priam's gates,
 young and old gathered together. Iris stood near,
 took the voice of Polites, Priam's son—the swift scout
 who sat atop old Aesyetes' highest tomb, watching
 for the Achaeans to depart from their ships—and spoke:
 "Old man, your speeches are always dear to you,
 as in peacetime; but war without respite has risen.
 I have entered many battles, yet never saw
 such a people, so many, moving across the plain,
 like leaves or grains of sand, to fight before the city.

Hector, I charge you above all: do this.
 Many allies dwell throughout Priam's great city,
 and many tongues belong to these scattered peoples.
 Let each commander signal those he rules,
 and marshal his own citizens and lead them out."
 So she spoke, and Hector understood the goddess.
 He swiftly dissolved the assembly. The gates opened wide;
 the people poured out, footmen and horsemen, and a great tumult rose.
 Before the city stood a steep, isolated, rounded hill,
 which men called Batieia, but immortals knew as the tomb
 of leaping Myrine. There the Trojans and their allies formed apart.
 Great Hector, crested in bronze, led the Trojans;
 with him, by far the greatest and best of the armed people,
 eager with their spears. Aeneas, noble son of Anchises,
 led the Dardanians—Aphrodite bore him to Anchises
 in the folds of Ida, when the goddess lay with a mortal.
 He was not alone: Antenor's two sons, Archelochus
 and Acamas, who knew every art of war, stood beside him.
 The Trojans of Zeleia, rich and drinking the dark water
 of the Aesepus beneath Ida's lowest foot, followed Pandarus,
 glorious son of Lycaon, to whom Apollo himself gave the bow.
 Adrastus and Amphius, lightly armored sons of Merops
 of Percote, led those who held Adrasteia, Apaesus,
 Pityeia, and steep Mount Tereia. Merops knew prophecy
 better than any man and forbade his sons to enter
 the death-bringing war, but the black Fates drove them on.
 Those who held Percote, Practius, Sestus, Abydos,
 and divine Arisba were led by Asius, son of Hyrtacides—
 Asius whom great, fiery horses brought from Arisba,
 beside the stream of Selleis.
 Hippothous and Pyleus, offshoots of Ares and sons
 of Pelasgian Lethus, led the spear-famed Pelasgians
 who dwelt in deep-soiled Larisa. Acamas and hero Pirous
 led the Thracians held within the rushing Hellespont;
 Euphemus, son of Troezenus and of Ceyx, led the spearmen
 of the Cicones. Pirechmes brought the Paeonians,
 their crooked bows, from distant Amydon beside broad Axios,

whose fairest water spreads across the land.
Great-hearted Pylaemenes led the Paphlagonians from Eneti,
where the race of wild asses is born; from Cytorus and Sesamus,
from their houses beside the Parthenius, from Cromna,
Aegialus, and the high Erythini. Odius and Epistrophus
led the Halizonians from distant Alybe, birthplace of silver.
Chromis and Ennomus the augur led the Mysians;
but augury could not save Ennomus from black death:
swift-footed Aeacides struck him down in the river,
where Achilles was slaughtering Trojans and their allies.
Phorcys and godlike Ascanius led the Phrygians,
come from far-off Ascania, eager for battle.
Mesthles and Antiphus, sons of Talaemenes,
whom the Gygaean lake bore, led the Maionians
born beneath Tmolus. Nastes led the Carians,
barbarous-speaking men from Miletus, Mount Phthira,
the banks of Maeander, and the steep peaks of Mycale.
Amphimachus and Nastes, splendid sons of Nomion,
led them. Nastes went to war wearing gold, like a girl,
a foolishness that could not ward off his grievous death;
swift-footed Aeacides killed him in the river,
and discerning Achilles carried off his gold.
Sarpedon and blameless Glaucus led the Lycians,
come from far Lycia, from the whirling Xanthus.

Source range: Book 2. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 3

First-pass working translation

When each army had taken its place beside its leaders,
the Trojans advanced with clamor and cries, like cranes
that fly before the sky, when they have escaped winter
and measureless rain, crying over the Ocean's streams,
carrying slaughter and death to the small Pygmy men;
high in the air they bring their evil quarrel.

The Achaeans moved in silence, breathing courage,
resolved in their hearts to defend one another.

As when the South Wind pours mist over a mountain's peaks—
unwelcome to shepherds, but better than night to a thief,
whose sight reaches no farther than a stone's throw—
so a storm of dust rose beneath their feet,
and they crossed the plain swiftly.

When they had come close to one another, godlike Alexander
stood before the Trojan ranks, wearing a leopard's skin,
curved bow, and sword; he brandished two bronze-tipped spears
and challenged every Argive champion to meet him face to face.

When war-loving Menelaus saw him striding before the host,
he rejoiced as a lion rejoices when he finds a great carcass—
a horned stag or wild goat—and hunger drives him to eat it,
though swift hounds and vigorous young hunters chase him.

So Menelaus rejoiced when his godlike enemy appeared;
he thought he would punish the man who had wronged him.

At once he leapt from his chariot in his armor.

But when godlike Alexander saw him among the champions,
his heart was struck with fear, and he withdrew into his people,
avoiding death. As when a man sees a serpent in a mountain ravine
and steps backward, trembling seizes his limbs, and pallor spreads
across his cheeks, so he sank again among the proud Trojans,
afraid of Atreus' son. Hector saw him and rebuked him:

“Paris, handsome beyond measure, mad for women, deceiver—
would that you had never been born, or died unmarried!

That would be my prayer, and far better than to be a disgrace,

a reproach to others. Surely the long-haired Achaeans laugh,
 thinking you a champion because your appearance is beautiful,
 though there is no strength in your heart, no courage.
 Was it as such a man that you crossed the sea in your ships,
 gathered loyal companions, mingled with foreign people,
 and carried a beautiful woman from a distant land,
 your father's great grief, your city's, and all the people's—
 a joy to the enemy, but shame to you? Will you not stand
 before war-loving Menelaus, so that you may know the man
 whose young wife you keep? Your lyre will not help you,
 nor Aphrodite's gifts, nor your hair nor your looks,
 when you lie in the dust. The Trojans are too fearful;
 you would already wear a stone tunic for all the evil you have done.”
 Godlike Alexander answered him: “Hector, since you have rebuked me
 with justice, not beyond it—your heart is hard and tireless,
 like an axe driven through a ship's timber by a skilled man,
 adding force to the man's stroke. So your mind within your breast
 is fearless. Do not throw up against me the lovely gifts
 of golden Aphrodite: the glorious gifts the gods give
 cannot be thrown away, and no man chooses them at will.
 If you wish me to fight, sit down the other Trojans and Achaeans;
 set Menelaus and me in the midst to fight over Helen
 and all her possessions. Let the better man, the stronger,
 take the woman and the goods and lead them home;
 the rest of you shall cut a faithful covenant,
 and dwell in fertile Troy, while they return to horse-breeding Argos
 and lovely Achaea.”
 Hector rejoiced to hear this great speech. He went into the midst
 and halted the Trojan ranks, gripping his spear by the middle.
 The long-haired Achaeans bent their bows and aimed stones,
 but Agamemnon cried aloud: “Hold, Argives! Do not shoot,
 young Achaeans. Crested Hector claims he will speak.”
 They stopped fighting and fell silent. Hector spoke between them:
 “Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans, and hear
 the word of Alexander, for whose sake this quarrel rose.
 Let the others lay their beautiful armor on the earth;
 let him and war-loving Menelaus alone fight in the midst

over Helen and all her possessions. Whoever wins and proves stronger,
 let him take all the goods and the woman home;
 the rest of us shall cut a covenant of friendship.”
 He spoke, and all were silent. Menelaus answered:
 “Hear me now as well. Most of all the pain reaches my heart.
 I think the Argives and Trojans should be separated now,
 since you have suffered much for my quarrel and Alexander’s beginning.
 Let the one for whom death and fate are made die;
 let the rest be parted quickly. Bring two lambs,
 one white and one black, for Earth and Sun, and another for Zeus.
 Bring mighty Priam, that he himself may cut the oath,
 for his sons are insolent and faithless, lest any man’s transgression
 destroy Zeus’s covenant. The minds of younger men are always shifting;
 an elder sees both before and behind, so that his counsel may be best
 for either side.”
 The Trojans and Achaeans rejoiced, hoping to end the wretched war.
 They drew back their horses, dismounted, stripped off their armor,
 and set it on the ground close together, leaving little space between.
 Hector sent two heralds toward the city to fetch lambs
 and call Priam, while Agamemnon sent Talthybius to the hollow ships
 to bring a lamb. Talthybius did not disobey the godlike king.
 Iris then came as a messenger to white-armed Helen,
 in the likeness of the wife of Antenor’s son, Helicaon,
 Laodice, fairest of Priam’s daughters. She found Helen
 in the chamber, weaving a great double-folded purple cloth,
 and embroidering upon it the many labors of the horse-taming
 Trojans and bronze-clad Achaeans—the sufferings they endured
 for her at the hands of Ares. Standing near, swift-footed Iris said:
 “Come, dear bride, and see the wondrous deeds of the horse-taming
 Trojans and bronze-clad Achaeans, those who once carried
 tearful Ares against one another in the hateful field,
 greedy for war. Now they sit in silence, leaning on their shields;
 their long spears stand planted beside them. Alexander and
 war-loving Menelaus will fight over you with their long spears;
 the victor will call you beloved wife.”
 So the goddess stirred in Helen’s heart a sweet desire
 for her former husband, her city, and her parents. At once,

veiling herself in bright white linen, she left the chamber,
shedding tender tears; she was not alone, for two attendants
followed her, Aethra, daughter of Pittheus, and ox-eyed Clymene.
Soon they reached the Scaean Gates.

Around Priam sat Panthous, Thymoetes, Lampus, Clytius,
Hicetaon, an offshoot of Ares, Ucalegon, and wise Antenor—
the city's elders, long since released from war by age,
but excellent speakers, like cicadas in the forest,
perched in trees and sending out their lily-clear voices.

Such were the Trojan leaders seated on the tower.

When they saw Helen coming onto the wall, they murmured softly:

"There is no blame if Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans
suffer long for such a woman. Terribly she resembles
an immortal goddess. Yet even so, let her return in the ships;
let her not remain here as a grief to us and our children."

Priam called Helen by name: "Come here, dear child, sit before me,
so that you may show me your former husband, your kinsmen, and friends.
You are not to blame in my eyes; the gods are to blame,
who brought this tearful war upon the Achaeans. Name for me this man,
that enormous Achaean, so strong and tall. There are others taller
in head, but I have never seen one so stately; he looks like a king."

Helen, divine among women, answered: "You are worthy of honor
and dreadful to me, dear father-in-law. Would that evil death
had pleased me when I followed your son here, leaving my chamber,
my kin, my darling child, and my beloved companions. It did not;
therefore I waste away in tears. I will tell you whom you ask about.

That is Atreus' son, wide-ruling Agamemnon, both a good king
and a strong spearman; once, if ever, he was my brother-in-law."

The old man admired him: "Happy Atreus' son, born under good fate,
blessed! Many sons of the Achaeans obey you. Once I entered
vine-rich Phrygia and saw the greatest number of Phrygian men,
with their dappled horses, the armies of Otreus and godlike Mygdon,
camped beside the banks of Sangarius. I too was numbered among
their allies, on the day the man-like Amazons came; but even they
were not as many as the bright-eyed Achaeans."

Then the old man saw Odysseus: "Tell me of this man, dear child.
He is shorter in head than Atreus' son, but broader in shoulders

and chest. His armor lies on the earth, while he moves through the ranks like a ram among a great flock of white sheep.”

Helen, daughter of Zeus, answered: “That is Laertes’ son, many-counseled Odysseus, raised in rocky Ithaca and skilled in every kind of trick and close-woven counsel.”

Wise Antenor replied: “Woman, your word is wholly true.

Once divine Odysseus came here with war-loving Menelaus as your embassy. I welcomed them in my house and entertained them; I learned the nature and the close counsel of both. When they stood among the gathered Trojans, Menelaus surpassed him in broad shoulders; but when both sat, Odysseus was the more majestic. When they wove speeches and plans before all, Menelaus spoke swiftly, few words, but very clear, since he was not a man of many words and was younger. When many-counseled Odysseus rose, he stood with eyes fixed on the ground, holding the scepter neither forward nor backward, but stiffly, like a man ignorant of the world—you might have called him angry and foolish. Yet when he sent his great voice from his chest, and words like winter snow, no mortal could contend with Odysseus; we no longer marveled at his appearance.”

The old man saw Ajax and asked: “Who is that other Achaeon, so strong and tall, the foremost of the Argives in head and broad shoulders?”

Helen, trailing her robe, answered: “That is towering Ajax, the bulwark of the Achaeans. On the other side stands Idomeneus among the Cretans, like a god; around him gather the Cretan leaders. Often war-loving Menelaus welcomed him in our house when he came from Crete. I see all the other bright-eyed Achaeans, whom I could recognize and name, but I cannot see the two commanders of the people, Castor, breaker of horses, and Polydeuces, good with the fists, my own brothers, born from the same mother as I. Either they did not come with the lovely Lacedaemonian army, or they came here in the ships, but now will not enter the battle, fearing the shame and many reproaches that are mine.”

So she spoke, but the life-giving earth already held them in Lacedaemon, in their dear native land.

At last Idaeus brought the victims from the city. Priam climbed down, and Agamemnon met him between the lines. The heralds gathered the oath-gifts of the gods; they mixed the wine in the bowl

and poured water over the hands of the kings. Agamemnon drew the knife that hung beside his great sword and cut hairs from the lambs' heads; Trojan and Achaean heralds distributed them to the best men. Atreus' son raised his hands and prayed:

"Father Zeus, most glorious and greatest, lord of Ida; Sun, who see and hear all things; rivers and earth; and you beneath, who punish the dead when anyone swears falsely—be witnesses, guard this faithful oath. If Alexander kills Menelaus, let him keep Helen and all her possessions, and let us return in our seafaring ships. If golden-haired Menelaus kills Alexander, let the Trojans return Helen and all her possessions, and pay the Argives the honor that is due, an honor remembered among men yet to come. If Priam and Priam's sons refuse to pay me the honor owed when Alexander has fallen, then I will remain here and fight on for compensation until I reach the war's end."

He cut the lambs' throats with pitiless bronze, and laid them on the earth, gasping as the metal took their strength. They drew wine from the bowl into cups and poured it out, praying to the everlasting gods. Someone among Trojans and Achaeans said:

"Father Zeus, greatest and most glorious, and all you other gods—whichever side first harms this oath, may their brains spill upon the ground as this wine does, their own and their children's; may their wives be taken by others."

So they spoke, but Cronus' son did not yet fulfill the prayer. Dardanian Priam addressed them: "Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans. I am going back to windy Ilium; I cannot bear with my own eyes to see my dear son fight war-loving Menelaus. Zeus and the other immortals know which of the two has been assigned the end of death."

He set the lambs in the chariot, mounted, and drew the reins back; Antenor climbed beside him, and they drove toward Ilium. Hector, Priam's son, and brilliant Odysseus first measured the ground. Then they shook lots in a bronze-studded helmet to decide who should cast his bronze spear first. The people prayed, raising their hands to the gods:

"Father Zeus, lord of Ida, most glorious and greatest, grant that the one who brought these deeds upon both peoples may die and enter the house of Hades, while friendship and faithful oaths

become ours.”

Hector shook the helmet and looked back; Paris’s lot leapt out first.
The men sat in their ranks where each man’s horses and bright armor lay.
Godlike Alexander, husband of fair-haired Helen, put on his armor:
first the beautiful greaves with silver ankle-clasps;
then the breastplate of his brother Lycaon, fitted to his body;
around his shoulders he hung the bronze sword with silver studs,
then the great, heavy shield. On his head he set the well-made horsehair
helmet, its crest nodding terribly above him, and took the strong spear
that fitted his palm. Menelaus armed himself in the same way.
They came from either side into the space between the armies,
looking terribly at one another; wonder seized the Trojans and Achaeans.
They stood close, measuring the ground, shaking their spears in anger.
Paris cast his long-shadowed spear first, striking Atreus’ son’s shield,
but the bronze did not break through; its point bent in the strong shield.
Menelaus, son of Atreus, prayed and cast his own:

“Father Zeus, grant that I may punish godlike Alexander,
who first wronged me; subdue him beneath my hands,
so that a man yet unborn may tremble to do evil to a host,
to one who offers friendship as a guest-friend.”

He hurled the long-shadowed spear. It struck Priam’s son’s shield,
passed through the shining metal, and lodged in the elaborate corselet;
it tore the tunic beside his flank, but Paris bent aside and escaped
the black Fates. Atreus’ son drew his silver-studded sword,
raised it, and struck the helmet’s crest. Around the helmet
the blade broke into three and four pieces and fell from his hand.
He groaned and looked into the broad sky:

“Father Zeus, no god is more destructive than you. I thought
I would punish Alexander for his evil, but now the sword has shattered
in my hands, and the spear flew uselessly from my palm.”

He sprang forward, seized the horsehair of Paris’s helmet,
and dragged him around toward the well-greaved Achaeans.
The embroidered chin-strap beneath his throat strangled him,
and he would have dragged him away and won immeasurable glory,
but Aphrodite, Zeus’s daughter, saw it and broke the strap
with the force of an ox slaughtered for sacrifice. The empty helmet
followed Menelaus’ strong hand. The hero whirled it and threw it

among the well-greaved Achaeans; his loyal companions carried it off. Menelaus rushed again, eager to kill him with bronze, but Aphrodite, easily as a goddess, snatched Paris away, wrapped him in dense mist, and set him down in his fragrant, incense-filled chamber.

Aphrodite went again to call white-armed Helen. She found her on the high tower, surrounded by many Trojan women. Taking the form of an old woman, a spinner who had lived beside Helen in Lacedaemon and whom she loved, the goddess shook her fragrant robe and spoke: “Come here. Alexander calls you home. He lies in his chamber, on the turned bed, shining in beauty and dress. You would not think he had come from fighting a man, but from a dance, or from sitting down after the dance.”

The goddess stirred Helen’s heart. When Helen saw her lovely throat, desiring breast, and flashing eyes, she marveled and named her: “Strange woman, why do you long to deceive me? Will you carry me farther, to one of the well-inhabited cities—Phrygia or lovely Maeonia—if there is another mortal man dear to you there? Menelaus has defeated godlike Alexander and wants to lead hateful me home. Is that why you stand here, weaving deceit? Go sit beside him yourself; leave the gods’ road, and do not turn your feet toward Olympus again. Worry over him always, until he makes you his wife—or his slave. I will not go there; it would be shameful to tend his bed. Every Trojan woman would reproach me; I carry unnumbered griefs within my heart.”

Golden Aphrodite answered in anger: “Do not provoke me, wretched woman, lest I abandon you in my anger. I will make you hated as terribly as I have loved you, and set hateful enmity between Trojans and Danaans; you will perish in an evil fate.”

Helen, daughter of Zeus, was afraid. She went silently, veiled in bright linen, unseen by all the Trojan women, and the goddess led her. When they reached Alexander’s beautiful house, the attendants turned quickly to work; Helen went into the high-roofed chamber. Smiling Aphrodite brought a chair and set it opposite Alexander. Helen sat, turned her eyes away, and rebuked her husband:

“You have come from war. Would that you had perished there, conquered by the strong man who was once my husband! You boasted before that you were better than war-loving Menelaus in strength, hands, and spear. Go now and challenge him again;

but I tell you: stop fighting him face to face, foolishly,
lest soon his spear bring you down.”

Paris answered: “Do not wound my heart with harsh reproaches.

Menelaus defeated me with Athena beside him; I will defeat him another time,
for we have gods with us. Come, let us turn to love and lie together.

Never before has desire so enveloped my mind—not even when I first
carried you away from lovely Lacedaemon in seafaring ships,
and joined with you in love and bed on Cranae’s island.

So now I love you, and sweet longing takes hold of me.”

He went first to the bed, and his wife followed. They slept in the bed’s
perforated frame, while Atreus’ son prowled through the host like a wild beast,
searching for Alexander; no Trojan or famous ally could point him out.

No one hid him from love—he was hateful to them all,
as hateful as black death. Agamemnon called across the ranks:

“Hear me, Trojans, Dardanians, and allies: victory plainly belongs
to war-loving Menelaus. Give up Argive Helen and the possessions with her,
and pay the honor that is due, an honor that will remain among men to come.”

So Atreus’ son spoke, and the other Achaeans applauded him.

Source range: Book 3. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 4

First-pass working translation

The gods sat beside Zeus, speaking in council on the golden floor;
among them royal Hebe poured nectar, and they received it in golden cups,
looking toward Priam's city. The son of Cronus tried to provoke Hera,
speaking with cutting words: "Two goddesses have aided Menelaus—
Argive Hera and Athena of Alalcomenae. They sit apart and rejoice,
but smiling Aphrodite always stands close to him and wards off the Fates;
even now she saved him when he thought he would die. Yet the victory
belongs to war-loving Menelaus. Let us consider what shall be done:
shall we stir dreadful war again, or place friendship between both peoples?
If this were pleasing to all, Priam's city might still be inhabited,
and Menelaus might lead Argive Helen home."

Athena and Hera muttered; seated close together, they planned evil for Troy.
Athena was silent, angry with her father, and fierce resentment held her.
Hera could not contain her anger: "Most terrible son of Cronus,
what have you said? Do you want to make my labor fruitless,
the sweat I spent in toil, while my horses were worn out gathering
the people for Priam and his sons? Do it—but none of the other gods
will praise you."

Cloud-gathering Zeus answered in deep displeasure: "Strange woman,
what have Priam and his sons done to you, that you rage without rest
to destroy well-built Ilium? If you could enter through the gates
and walls and devour Priam, his sons, and the other Trojans raw,
then your anger might be healed. Do as you wish; let this quarrel
between us not become a great dispute later. I say this also:
when I desire to destroy a city where your beloved people live,
do not delay my anger, but let me act. For I gave way to you,
though unwillingly; of all the cities beneath the sun and starry sky,
holy Ilium, Priam, and his well-speared people were most dear to me.
Never did my altar lack its equal feast, libation, or savor of sacrifice;
that honor was our portion."

Ox-eyed Hera replied: "Three cities are most dear to me—Argos,
Sparta, and broad-wayed Mycenae. Destroy them when they anger you;
I will not stand before you or begrudge it. But my labor must not be

made fruitless. I too am a goddess, born from the same source as you; Cronus of crooked counsel bore me eldest, and I am called your wife, while you rule among all the immortals. Let us yield to one another, you to me and I to you; the other gods will follow. Now command Athena to go quickly into the grievous battle of Trojans and Achaeans, and see whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans, in violation of the oaths.”

Her father and the father of gods did not disobey. He spoke winged words to Athena: “Go quickly among Trojans and Achaeans. See whether the Trojans will first harm the illustrious Achaeans in violation of the oaths.”

So he urged Athena, already eager; she shot down from Olympus’ peaks, like the bright star that Cronus’ son sends as a sign to sailors or a great army, from which many sparks leap. In its likeness Pallas Athena rushed to earth and leapt into the midst; wonder seized the horse-taming Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans. Each man said to the one beside him: “Will dreadful war rise again, or will Zeus establish friendship between them?”

Athena entered the Trojan crowd in the likeness of Laodocus, son of Antenor, a strong spearman, seeking godlike Pandarus.

She found Lycaon’s blameless, powerful son standing among the dense ranks of shield-bearing men who had followed him from the streams of Aesepus.

Standing near, she spoke: “Would you obey me, Lycaon’s son?

Would you dare shoot a swift arrow at Menelaus? You would win favor and glory from all the Trojans, above all from King Alexander.

He would be the first to give you shining gifts if he saw Menelaus, son of Atreus, struck by your arrow and climbing onto the grievous pyre.

Shoot glorious Menelaus; vow to Apollo, famous archer of Lycia, that when you return to sacred Zeleia you will sacrifice a splendid hecatomb of first-born lambs.”

The goddess persuaded the foolish man. He took down his polished bow, made from the horns of a wild goat that he himself had struck beneath the breast as it sprang from rock; the animal fell backward upon the stone.

Its horns grew sixteen palms; a horn-worker joined and polished them, and set a golden tip upon them. Pandarus laid the bow carefully, and his excellent companions held their shields before him, lest the warlike sons of the Achaeans leap forward before Menelaus was struck.

He opened the lid of his quiver and drew an arrow not yet shot, the source of black pain. Quickly he fitted the bitter arrow to the string,

and vowed again to Apollo. He drew together the notch and ox-hide string; the great bow bent in a circle, twanged, the string cried loudly, and the sharp arrow leapt through the host eager to fly. Yet the blessed gods had not forgotten you, Menelaus. First Athena, the spoil-taking daughter of Zeus, stood before you and turned away the deadly arrow, as a mother brushes a fly from her child asleep. She guided it to the place where the golden clasps of the belt held fast, where the double breastplate met. The bitter arrow struck the fitted belt, passed through the decorated belt and elaborate corselet, and pierced the guard that protected the skin from spears—the guard that saved him most, though the arrow passed beyond it and grazed his flesh. Dark blood immediately ran from the wound. As a Maeonian or Carian woman stains ivory with purple to adorn a horse's cheek—kept in a chamber, desired by many riders, an ornament and glory for horse and charioteer—so your well-formed thighs and beautiful legs, Menelaus, were stained with blood. When Agamemnon saw the dark blood running from the wound, he trembled; war-loving Menelaus trembled too, but when he saw the sinew and arrow-barbs outside, his heart gathered itself again. Agamemnon groaned heavily, holding Menelaus' hand, while his companions lamented:

“Dear brother, I cut the oath that set you alone before the Achaeans to fight the Trojans, and the Trojans have struck you and trampled the faithful oath. Yet the oath, the blood of lambs, the unmixed libations, and the right hands we trusted will not be in vain. Even if Olympus' lord does not fulfill it at once, he will fulfill it later, and they will pay dearly, with their heads, wives, and children. I know this in my heart: the day will come when holy Ilium, Priam, and Priam's well-speared people are destroyed, when Zeus himself, dwelling in the upper air, shakes his dark aegis over them in anger at this deceit. These things will not fail; but my grief for you, Menelaus, will be terrible if you die and fulfill the appointed end of life.”

Menelaus answered: “Take heart, and do not alarm the army. The wound is not deadly; the arrow's sharp point did not remain, and the belt and corselet held it back.”

Agamemnon summoned Talthybius: “Call Machaon, son of Asclepius, the blameless healer, to see whether he can heal Menelaus.”

Talthybius went through the ranks and found Machaon, a good physician, standing among the shield-bearing men who had followed him from Tricca.

He brought him before Menelaus. Machaon cut away the shining belt,
the corselet, and the guard; he drew the clotted blood from the wound
and laid soothing medicines upon it—medicines given by Cheiron
to his father, Asclepius, long ago.

Then Agamemnon moved through the ranks. He praised the brave,
and rebuked the hesitant, for kings must kindle courage.

He spoke to the Cretans, to the men of Athens and Argos,
to those who loved battle and those who stood unwilling:

“Friends, remember the oath. The gods are not blind.

Those who fight with all their strength will receive honor;
those who hide behind the others will return without a name.”

The armies met. No herald could stop them now.

The chariots rolled, the dust rose, and bronze struck bronze.

Men fell on every side. Antilochus killed Echepolus;

Elephenor dragged the dead man's armor away, but Agenor
struck him beneath the ribs, and the Achaeans lost their man.

Then war gathered itself into countless separate deaths.

One man cast a spear; another caught it on the shield.

Here the son of a king fell; there a nameless soldier
left the light. The dust drank blood. The earth was trampled,
and Zeus watched the promise of the war grow heavier.

Ajax killed Simoeisius, son of Anthemion, whose mother
had borne him beside the banks of Simoeis. He had not lived
long enough to repay his parents' care. Like a slender poplar
grown in a watered meadow, he fell beneath the spear.

Antiphus, Priam's son, cast at Ajax and struck Leucus,
Odysseus' companion, who was dragging a body from the field.

The corpse fell from his hands. Odysseus was filled with anger.

He advanced into the foremost ranks, and the Trojans retreated.

Democoon fell beneath his spear. Odysseus struck him at the temple,
and the bronze passed through. The Trojans shuddered and withdrew,
but Hector drove them forward again, like a winter flood
that leaps a bank and carries away the shepherd's flock.

The Achaeans fought in ordered silence. The Trojans cried aloud,
each man calling the name of a brother or a friend. The sound
of battle filled the plain, and neither side could see the end.

Diomedes entered the fight like a winter torrent,

when rain has swollen the mountain streams and the old banks
cannot hold them. No wall, no bridge, no field remains secure.
He struck Astynous and Hypeiron, took the life of one
with a spear, of the other with a sword, and stripped their arms.
He came upon Abas and Polyidus, sons of Eurydamas,
who had read dreams but not their own death. Diomedes killed them.
Then he overthrew Xanthus and Thoon, twin sons of Phaenops,
whose old father had no other children to comfort his age.
Diores fell, struck in the ankle by a stone. Peirous, his killer,
was pierced beneath the navel by Thoas; his entrails spilled,
and he fell in the dust. The two armies drew together around them,
like wolves, with no thought of flight.
The sons of Antenor—Archelochus, Acamas, and Iphidamas—
entered the fight. Iphidamas had been raised in Thrace,
and had married a bride but left her bed to answer Troy's call.
Agamemnon struck him beneath the belt; the spear entered deep.
The old father looked upon the son and mourned in silence.
Coon, the eldest, came against Agamemnon. He wounded him
below the elbow and called his brothers to carry Iphidamas away.
Agamemnon killed Coon and drove on, though blood ran down his arm.
The battle spread. Menelaus killed Pylæmenes; Meriones killed
Phereclus, maker of ships. Teucer shot Orsilochus and Chromius,
and Ajax struck Amphius. Nestor's son Antilochus brought down
Ablerus; Diomedes killed Axylus, who had welcomed strangers
beside his road, but none of them could save him now.
As fire consumes a dry forest upon the mountain slopes,
driven by a wind that turns every tree into a red wave,
so the two peoples moved across the plain. No man who entered
that fire knew whether he would return to the bright day.
Hector saw the Achaeans pressing forward and urged his men.
Agamemnon saw his brother's wound forgotten and the army advancing.
The gods sat apart, but no god's counsel could withdraw
the oath's broken violence from the hands of mortals.
At last the battle darkened toward evening. The slain lay thick,
and the living still sought armor among them. The earth groaned
under the feet of men and horses. Night would bring a brief pause,
but not peace: Troy and Argos had already taken up the sword again.

Source range: Book 4. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 5

First-pass working translation

Then Athena gave Diomedes, son of Tydeus, courage and grace,
so that he might shine among the Argives, and win lasting honor.
She drove the mist from his eyes, that he might know a god
from a man. “Fight the Trojans,” she said, “but do not contend
with any god except Aphrodite. If she enters the battle,
strike her with the bronze.”

Diomedes rushed ahead, like a lion that has been wounded
but not subdued. He killed Phegeus and Idæus, sons of Dares,
a priest of Hephaestus. Phegeus fell from his chariot;
Idæus fled, leaving the beautiful armor behind. Hephaestus
saved him, hiding him in mist, for he would not see
the house of Dares left empty of sons.

The Trojans fled. Pandarus saw Diomedes and drew his bow.
He struck him in the shoulder; the arrow passed through,
and blood ran down his armor. Pandarus cried aloud:

“I have wounded him! Let me mount my chariot and finish him.”

Aeneas answered: “Come, and let us seek him. If we delay,
we shall not hold the field.” They drove toward Diomedes.

Sthenelus saw the arrow and pulled it from the wound.

Diomedes prayed to Athena:

“Hear me, daughter of Zeus. If you ever loved my father,
stand beside me now. Let me reach the two men who wounded me.”

Athena answered: “Be bold. I have taken the mist from your eyes.

You will know gods from men, and no weapon will turn you back.”

Diomedes struck Pandarus beneath the ear. The bronze broke
through his teeth, and the spear passed under the tongue.

He fell from the chariot. Aeneas stood over the body,
protecting his comrade, like a lion before his cubs.

Diomedes threw a stone and crushed Aeneas' hip. Aphrodite,
his mother, came near him, shielding him with her shining arms.

Diomedes recognized the goddess and struck her at the wrist.

The immortal blood ran, and she cried out, releasing her son.

Iris led her away in the chariot of Ares. The goddess mounted,

her horses dark with fear; she climbed Olympus and knelt
beside her mother Dione. Dione embraced her and said:
“Endure, child. The gods have suffered at mortal hands before.
Otus and Ephialtes bound Ares; Hera was struck by Amphitryon;
Hades himself was pierced by Heracles. Mortal strength
may touch the deathless when a god permits it.”
Apollo carried Aeneas from the battlefield, covering him
with a dark cloud. He set him in Pergamus, and Artemis healed
the wound. Apollo made a likeness of Aeneas, and the Trojans
and Achaeans fought around it, while he called to Ares:
“Ares, turn this man of conflict against Diomedes.
Draw back the gods who protect the Argives, and strengthen Hector.”
Ares descended in the shape of Acamas and shouted to the Trojans.
Hector rallied them. Sarpedon rebuked him for standing apart,
and Hector led the men forward. The ranks closed again.
Diomedes killed Astynous and Hypeiron; Agamemnon struck
two more. Odysseus fought beside the wounded. Ares took the side
of Troy, and Athena stood near Diomedes. She guided his spear
against the mortal places and told him:
“If Ares comes against you, drive the bronze into his belly.
Do not fear the god of battle.”
Diomedes mounted the chariot with Athena. They charged.
Ares threw his spear, but Athena turned it aside. Diomedes cast,
and the weapon entered below the ribs of Ares. The god cried out
as loudly as nine thousand or ten thousand men cry in battle.
The Trojans and Achaeans shook at the sound.
Ares rose like a dark storm and went to Olympus. He complained
to Zeus: “You allow Athena to drive mortals against the gods.
She has filled Diomedes with madness. He would fight his father
if he stood before him. I am wounded, and my blood runs immortal.”
Zeus answered with a thunderous look: “Do not sit beside me
complaining. You are the most hateful god to me. You delight
in strife, and your mother gave you an ungoverned heart.
Still, I will not let you suffer forever.”
He ordered Paeon to heal him, and Hebe washed his wound.
Soon Ares stood whole again, but the battle below had changed.
Hera and Athena returned to the field. Hera called to Zeus:

“Will you let Diomedes be destroyed by Ares? Let us help him.”
Zeus consented. They drove toward the army, and Athena put on the helmet of Hades, which makes its wearer unseen. She seized the goad, and moved unseen beside Diomedes. The mortal heard her: “Drive on. Do not shrink. The son of Tydeus must know no fear. Strike Ares, and let him learn that a god who enters men’s war may be met by the courage he teaches them.”
Diomedes threw the spear. Athena guided it into Ares’ body. When the god fell, a black stone would not have made a larger crash. The earth groaned beneath him. Ares rose in agony and fled. Athena and Hera returned to Olympus. The Trojan line collapsed around Hector. Sarpedon lifted the people of Lycia and urged them: “Do not retreat. We have come to die beside this city. If we were immortal, we would never fear the day of battle. But death is appointed to all, and glory remains with the bold.” Sarpedon and Glaucus drove forward. They found Tlepolemus, son of Heracles, and the two leaders exchanged spears. Tlepolemus struck Sarpedon’s thigh; Sarpedon pierced Tlepolemus beneath the ear. Both fell, and each army mourned. Sarpedon prayed to Apollo for healing, but the god did not answer. The Lycian people carried him away, and Glaucus’ wound was eased when Apollo heard his prayer. He urged the Trojans to defend the body, and the fight around Sarpedon grew fierce. Hector and the Trojans attacked. The Achaeans did not yield. Ajax and Teucer came near; Teucer shot a captain, but Hector shattered his bow. Ajax held his shield before his brother, and they withdrew together beneath the pressure of the line. Sarpedon fell like an oak cut down by the axe. The dust covered him, and the armor flashed around his body. Zeus looked upon his son, and wanted to save him. Hera warned him: “If you take him from death, the other gods will demand the same. Let fate stand. Send Apollo to wash him, and let Sleep and Death carry him to Lycia, where his people will bury him.” Zeus listened. He sent a rain of blood upon the field, honoring his son before the appointed hour. Apollo came, washed Sarpedon in the river, and wrapped him in divine garments. Sleep and Death bore him away, swift as twin brothers,

to the far land where the Lycian people received him.
Meanwhile the Achaeans seized the armor. Patroclus urged
Eurypylus forward, and he killed Hypsenor, priest of the river.
The Trojans retreated toward the city, but the gods stirred
the war again, and the day did not close with victory.
Diomedes, Odysseus, and the two Ajaxes pressed upon the enemy.
Hector drove back the men before him. Aeneas returned,
healed and armed, and the Trojans took heart. The plain filled
with chariots, horses, and wounded men. Night did not yet come;
the battle still burned with the force of a god.

Source range: Book 5. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 6

First-pass working translation

The battle went on, and the gods were not beside the men.
The Argives pressed, and the Trojans gave ground beneath them.
Ajax killed Hyrtacides, and Antilochus struck down a captain;
the field ran red, and no one could count the dead.
Glaucus and Diomedes met between the armies.
They raised their spears, but Diomedes asked:
“Who are you, my friend? I have never seen you in battle.
You are bold to stand before me. Better not to meet me.
Tell me your name. No man lives long who fights my spear.”
Glaucus answered: “Why ask my birth? It is like the leaves.
The wind scatters them, and spring gives others to the wood.
So one generation grows, and another falls. Yet hear my lineage.
My father was Hippolochus, son of Bellerophon,
whom the gods loved, though he too learned mortal grief.
Bellerophon was sent to Lycia with a folded message,
which commanded his death. The king's daughter desired him,
but he would not betray his guest. The king, angered, sent him
against the Chimera, the fire-breathing beast of divine blood.
He killed it, and the Solymi, and the Amazons in battle.
At last he wandered alone, hated by the gods, upon the plain.
I am his grandson. My house is honored in Lycia.”
Diomedes answered: “Then you are an old guest-friend of mine.
Oeneus once welcomed Bellerophon into his house for twenty days.
They exchanged bright gifts: a purple belt for a golden cup.
Therefore I will not fight you. You are my friend across the ranks.
Let us exchange armor, so that all men may know this bond.”
They leapt from their chariots and clasped hands.
Zeus took Glaucus' sense away, for he gave golden armor
worth a hundred cattle for bronze worth only nine.
Meanwhile Hector entered the city and called to the women:
“Go to the temples. Pray to Athena, and promise a robe,
the finest and largest, to hang across her knees. Ask her
to turn Diomedes from the city, and save Troy's children.”

The women climbed to the temple, led by Hector's mother.

The priestess set the robe upon Athena's knees and prayed:

"Lady, break the spear of Tydeus' son. Save Troy."

But Athena did not hear.

Hector searched the city for Paris. He found him in his chamber,

polishing his armor, while Helen sat beside him. Hector said:

"The army is dying outside, and you remain here. You are the cause of this war, and yet you do not fight. Rise, before the city burns."

Paris answered: "You speak rightly. I did not stay from anger,

but from shame. Helen has urged me to return to battle.

Wait for me; I will follow."

Helen said to Hector: "Brother, I am a hateful woman,

and I wish the storm had taken me before I came here.

Sit and rest. Your labor is too great; you carry the city alone.

Paris has brought this evil upon us, and I upon myself."

Hector answered: "Do not ask me to rest while the army fights.

I must go. I fear for the women and children of Troy,

and for you too, though you are the cause of our sorrow."

He turned and went through the streets. His wife Andromache

met him at the Scaean gate, holding their little son Astyanax.

The child clung to his nurse and cried at the horsehair crest,

terrified by the bronze and by the spear that Hector carried.

Hector smiled, took off his helmet, and set it shining on the ground.

He lifted his son, kissed him, and prayed to Zeus:

"Grant that this child may be greater than I, and rule Troy.

Let men say, 'He is better than his father,' when he returns

from battle, bringing the armor of an enemy he has killed.

Let his mother's heart rejoice."

He placed the boy in Andromache's arms. She wept and spoke:

"Your strength will kill you. You have no pity for me,

or for the child who has no other father. Achilles killed

my father and my seven brothers; he took my mother away.

You are father, mother, brother, and husband to me.

Stay here upon the wall. Do not make your child an orphan

and me a widow. Place the army by the fig tree,

where the wall is easiest to climb."

Hector answered: "I know it all. But I would die of shame

before the Trojans and the women of Troy if I shrank from war.
 My heart forbids it. I have learned to be brave, and always
 to fight among the foremost, winning great honor for my father.
 Yet a day will come when sacred Troy will fall, and Priam,
 and all his people. But I grieve less for them than for you:
 some bronze-clad Achaean will carry you away, and you will weave
 for another woman, or draw water from another's spring.
 Then someone will say, 'That was the wife of Hector,
 best of the horsemen when Troy fought.' Those words will deepen
 your grief. May the earth lie over me before I hear your crying."
 He reached for his son, but the child had turned toward the nurse,
 afraid of the helmet's horsehair and the bronze's shining face.
 Hector laughed, removed the helmet, and set it on the ground.
 He kissed his son, rocked him, and gave him back to Andromache.
 She smiled through tears. Hector took her hand:
 "Do not grieve beyond measure. No man can send me to Hades
 before my appointed day. No one, coward or brave, escapes fate.
 Return to the house. Care for your weaving, your servants,
 and our child. The war belongs to all the men of Troy,
 but most of all to me."
 Andromache went home, turning often to look back at him,
 weeping as she went. The women who followed her wept also,
 for they believed Hector would not return alive.
 Paris came at last, bright in his armor. He called to Hector:
 "I am ready. Do not wait."
 Hector answered: "No one can blame you for battle now.
 You are beautiful and swift, but your heart has been slow.
 Come, and let us fight while the city still stands."
 They passed through the gates and entered the battle.
 The Argives retreated, but the Trojans regained courage.
 Helenus, who knew the will of the gods, told Hector and Paris
 to call the champions back into the field. The war gathered
 again around the walls, while Andromache reached her chamber,
 and her women remembered the man who had just left them.

Source range: Book 6. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 7

First-pass working translation

Hector and Paris moved through the ranks, and the Achaeans held.
Apollo and Athena watched from above. At last Apollo spoke:
“Why do we set these men against one another in slaughter?
Let Hector challenge the best of the Argives. Let one man fight
one man, and let the armies rest while they decide.”
Athena agreed, and Helenus heard the gods' counsel. He came near
Hector and said: “Call the Achaeans to choose a champion.
Let him fight you. You may die, but your name will endure;
or you will kill him, and the Trojans will take his armor.”
Hector went between the armies and raised his voice:
“Let both sides cease. I will speak. Zeus has not granted us
the final end of war. First, let one of the Achaeans come against me.
I will stand before him, and the better man shall take the arms.
Let the living carry them home. We will make a truce over the dead.”
The Argives sat in silence. No one wished to face Hector.
Menelaus rebuked them:
“Shame on us, women, and not men! If none will stand,
I will go. The outcome lies in the hands of Zeus.”
Agamemnon answered: “You are brave, but not alone. There are others
who wish to meet him.” Nine men rose: Agamemnon, Diomedes,
the two Ajaxes, Idomeneus, Meriones, Eurypylus, Thoas, and Odysseus.
They cast lots. The sign fell to Ajax, son of Telamon.
Ajax rejoiced, put on his armor, and came to the open ground.
He looked like a dark tower, and Hector's heart was glad to see him.
The heralds marked a boundary, and both armies watched in fear.
Ajax threw first. His spear struck Hector's shield,
but did not pass through. Hector cast, and the point entered
the sevenfold hide beneath Ajax's shield, cutting his throat,
but the black wool stopped it. Ajax lifted a great stone,
which two men could scarcely carry, and struck Hector's shield.
The rim broke; Hector fell backward, but Apollo raised him.
Hector cast again. Ajax received the blow and answered,
striking Hector's neck. Blood flowed, but Hector did not yield.

The two men fought with swords. Ajax broke through the helmet;
Hector's head streamed with dust. The armies cried out,
and each prayed that his champion might survive.
At last heralds came from both sides: Idaeus for Troy,
and Talthibius for the Argives. They raised their staffs:
“Stop, sons of great fathers. Zeus loves you both.
Night is upon us; let night divide the battle.”
Ajax answered: “Idaeus speaks rightly. Let Hector take the truce.
He has come to meet me, and I honor him.”
Hector said: “Let us exchange gifts, so that men may say:
‘They fought with hatred, yet parted with friendship.’”
He gave Ajax a sword with its sheath and belt;
Ajax gave Hector a purple war-belt, bright with metal.
The two armies withdrew. The Achaeans welcomed Ajax,
and the Trojans welcomed Hector. Priam called his son to the city.
The Argives gathered in Agamemnon's tent, and sacrificed an ox.
They ate and drank while Nestor rose among them:
“Let us build a wall beside the ships, with a deep trench outside.
The wall will protect the camp and the vessels, though I know
the gods built Troy's wall for Laomedon, and ours will not last.
Still, while we remain, we need a defense.”
All agreed. Through the night they drove stakes and piled stones.
The gods watched from Olympus. Poseidon complained to Zeus:
“These mortals have built a wall beside the sea without an offering.
Its fame will eclipse the wall we made for Troy. When the war is over,
they will forget our labor.”
Zeus answered: “Do not be angry. When the Achaeans depart,
you and Apollo may sweep the wall into the sea. Let the waves
cover it, so that its memory will not compete with yours.”
At dawn the Achaeans finished their work. Ships arrived from Lemnos,
bringing wine. Every man bought what he needed. The army feasted,
while the Trojans sat in fear, not eating, for grief stood near them.
Priam called a council. Antenor said: “Return Helen and her wealth.
The war has consumed us.” Paris refused to give back the woman,
but offered all the treasure and more. The Trojans accepted his word,
though Agamemnon would not accept it when Idaeus carried it to camp.
The herald said: “Paris will not return Helen, but he will return

the wealth she brought, and add to it from his own house.”

Agamemnon answered: “No. We have suffered too much to bargain.

The Trojans must yield the woman, or continue the war.”

Night spread over the camp. The Achaeans slept beside their ships,

but Hector and the Trojans watched the fire upon the plain.

The future stood before them, bright with battle and dark with loss.

Source range: Book 7. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 8

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose, and Zeus called the gods to council. He spoke:
“No god shall help the Trojans or the Argives today.
If I find one descending to the battle, I will seize him
and cast him into Tartarus, far below the earth and sea.
Then he will know that I am stronger than all the immortals.
Look at the chain I could hang from heaven: all gods together
could not pull me down, while I could lift earth and sea.”
The gods sat silent. Zeus mounted his chariot, took the reins,
and drove from Olympus. He came to Ida, rich in springs,
and sat upon Gargarus, beneath an oak. The armies met below.
The Trojans crossed the plain with Hector leading them.
Zeus lifted the scales of fate, and Hector's side rose high;
the day of the Achaeans fell. Thunder rolled above the field.
Hector drove the Argives back. Teucer stood with his bow,
and shot eight men, but Hector's ninth arrow struck him.
The bow fell, and Ajax covered him with his shield.
Idomeneus and Diomedes fought near the wall, but the Trojans
pressed like a fire through dry grass. The Achaeans turned
their chariots toward the ships, and the night grew near.
Agamemnon raised his hands to Zeus:
“Father, if you ever heard a prayer from an Achaean,
grant us escape. Let the army live, though you will not give
us victory. Do not let Hector drive us into the sea.”
Zeus heard. He thundered, and the Argives took courage,
but they still retreated. Hector called the Trojans forward:
“Do not stop to strip the dead. Whoever leaves the line
to gather armor shall die beside the ships. Tonight we camp
in the open field, and the Argives will not sleep in safety.”
The Trojans seized the bodies and stripped the fallen.
The Achaeans crossed their trench and reached the wall.
Nestor's horses stumbled. His chariot broke, and he stood alone.
Diomedes saw him and called:
“Old king, climb into my chariot. Leave your horses.

We must reach the line before Hector takes you.”

Nestor mounted. Diomedes drove straight at Hector, though Zeus’ thunder rolled above them. Hector saw the chariot and told his men to stand. The two champions cast their spears; Diomedes struck Eniopeus, Hector’s charioteer, in the chest. The man fell, and Hector mourned him, but seized the reins. Diomedes hurled again, hoping to reach Hector. Zeus broke the spear’s point and made it fall before the chariot. Diomedes understood the warning. Nestor said: “Turn back. No man can fight the son of Cronus today.”

Diomedes answered: “I hate to hear such words. If Hector boasts, he will say that fear drove me away.”

Nestor replied: “You will not be called a coward. The gods themselves have made this day his. Live, and fight tomorrow.” They withdrew. Hector shouted: “Diomedes, why do you run? You feared my spear before; now you fear my chariot too. Go, and tell the women of Argos how Hector drove you.”

Diomedes turned three times, wishing to answer, but thunder struck from Ida. Nestor cried: “Do not resist the god.”

The Argives reached the wall and gathered behind it. Hera and Athena watched from Olympus, grieving. Zeus saw them and said: “Why do you sit apart? You cannot oppose my will. Diomedes is no match for Hector, whom I have raised today.”

Hera answered: “You are strongest, but we too feel pity. Let us go to the army, though we do not wish to change fate.”

Zeus sent Iris to order them back. She came to the chariot: “Return. Zeus says no god may help the Achaeans.”

Hera replied in anger: “Let him threaten. We are his family, but he does not command our hearts.” Still they turned back. The Achaeans reached the ships. The Trojans did not camp in the city; Hector ordered fires throughout the field, so that no man could escape in the darkness. A thousand fires burned, and beside each sat fifty men. Hector stood among them, praying to Zeus:

“Grant me to take the wall and set fire to the ships. Then I will not ask for more, and the Achaeans will flee.”

Zeus nodded, though he knew the prayer would one day fail.

The Trojans ate beside the fires. Their horses stood ready,
and the camp shone across the plain like a city under stars.
In the Achaean camp, Agamemnon called an assembly.
He wept openly and said: "Friends, Zeus has abandoned us.
Let us launch the ships and return. Troy is too strong."
Diomedes rose: "The king speaks in fear. Let us stay.
The gods may turn again. A brave man does not abandon the field."
The people shouted approval. Nestor praised him and advised
that the dead be guarded, the trench repaired, and the wall held.
They ate and drank. Night settled over both armies,
but Hector and the Trojans kept watch beneath the fires.
The Achaeans lay near the ships, fearing the morning.

Source range: Book 8. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 9

First-pass working translation

The Achaeans were driven back, and fear stood among them.
Agamemnon called the elders to council. He wept and said:
“Friends, Zeus has caught me in a ruinous error. Let us launch
the ships and flee. Troy is too strong, and the god has turned away.”
Diomedes rose: “Atreus’ son, you may leave if you wish.
The rest of us will stay. We came here under fate. A man who runs
from battle cannot command those who remain. Let the army fight.”
The chiefs praised him. Nestor, wise in counsel, spoke:
“Agamemnon, the fault is yours. You angered Achilles and took
his prize, though he is the best among us. Give back Briseis,
and send gifts beyond counting. Go to his tent and ask forgiveness.
Let Phoenix, Ajax, and Odysseus carry your words.”
Agamemnon answered: “I was blinded by delusion. I will make amends.
I will give seven tripods, twenty shining cauldrons, and talents of gold;
cities I took in Thrace; and when we reach Troy, Achilles may choose
twenty Trojan women. I will return Briseis untouched, and swear
I have not approached her bed. If he returns, he will be honored
like my own brother. Let the gifts be carried to him now.”
They loaded the gifts upon wagons, and the heralds led the way.
Odysseus and Ajax went to Achilles’ shelter, with Phoenix beside them.
They found him playing a lyre, singing of the deeds of heroes.
Patroclus sat in silence opposite him. Achilles saw the embassy,
and said: “Welcome. Even when I am angry, you are dear to me.”
They ate and drank. Odysseus rose with the cup:
“Achilles, son of Peleus, the Achaeans need you. Hector has reached
the wall and the ships. Agamemnon offers gifts, and promises Briseis;
he swears he has not touched her. Take the gifts, and return.
If you wait, Troy may burn the ships, and the army will have no escape.”
Achilles answered: “Son of Laertes, what a waste of words!
I hate a man who hides one thought and speaks another.
Agamemnon and I are enemies. He has no right to my gifts.
Though I fight, the coward and the brave receive the same fate.
I have labored without rest, and he keeps the greater prize.

My mother told me that two fates carry me: if I stay at Troy,
 my homecoming is lost, but my name will live; if I sail home,
 my fame will die, but my life will be long. I would choose life,
 if honor had not been stolen from me. Why should I fight for him?
 The gifts are not worth the life of a man. The cattle, cities,
 and women can be taken again; but a man's breath, once gone,
 does not return. I will not go. At dawn I will launch my ships.
 Let every man who wishes sail. The gods can save the Achaeans.”
 Odysseus returned to the council and told them the answer.
 The chiefs sat in grief. Diomedes said: “Let us eat and sleep.
 Tomorrow we will fight. A man who trusts his own courage need not
 beg another's help.”
 Phoenix remained with Achilles. He said:
 “My son, your father sent me to teach you speech and action.
 I remember when I fled my father after a quarrel over a woman.
 He cursed me, but the gods and your father received me.
 I became nurse to you, and carried you in my arms.
 Do not make your heart like stone. The gods themselves accept prayers,
 though men have angered them. The gifts are large, and Agamemnon
 has admitted his error. If he still offends you, fight for us,
 not for him. Your fame will grow when you save the army.”
 Achilles answered: “Old Phoenix, my heart honors you. Sleep here,
 and come with me when I sail, if you wish. Do not persuade me.”
 Ajax then spoke: “Achilles, we sit like beggars before you.
 No gift can move you, and no argument. A man may forgive his enemy
 when the enemy has killed his brother; yet you refuse forgiveness
 for a woman. Come with us. We honor you, though you have hardened
 your heart. If Hector reaches the ships, we will remember this night.”
 Achilles replied: “Ajax speaks plainly, and I respect him.
 But Agamemnon has dishonored me. I will not return while the anger
 remains. When Hector reaches my own ship, then perhaps I will fight.”
 The envoys went back. The assembly heard that Achilles would not yield.
 They ate and slept beside the ships, while Hector gathered his army.
 The night was full of fear, and no man saw the morning as secure.

Source range: Book 9. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 10

First-pass working translation

The other chiefs slept beside the ships, but Agamemnon could not.
He watched the Trojan fires and heard the cries across the plain.
He tore his hair and looked toward the sea, fearing for the army.
At last he went to Nestor. “Old friend, wake. We need counsel.
Hector has driven us against the ships. Is there a man who will go
through the darkness and learn whether the Trojans sleep or plan attack?”
Nestor rose and called Diomedes, Odysseus, and the two Ajaxes,
Meriones and Menelaus. They armed themselves. Nestor said:
“Let the bravest volunteer. Whoever goes must be swift and wise.”
Diomedes chose Odysseus. The two put on helmets and armor,
though Diomedes took no shield, trusting the dark to cover him.
Athena sent a heron to the right. They prayed, and began to cross
the ditch, stepping among the bodies and abandoned weapons.
Hector too called a spy. He promised a chariot and fine armor
to the man who would enter the Achaean camp. Dolon, son of Eumedes,
volunteered. He put on a wolf-skin, took a bow, and ran across the field.
Odysseus and Diomedes saw him. They crouched among the corpses.
Dolon passed, believing he had escaped notice. Diomedes sprang,
and Dolon stopped, trembling. He begged:
“Take my armor, but do not kill me. I will tell you everything.
Hector sent me. He promised great gifts, but no Trojan knows
what he will do with a man once the danger has passed.”
Odysseus asked him about the camp: Where were the guards?
Which men were newly arrived, and which were farthest from Hector?
Dolon named the Thracians, who had just come, with their king Rhesus.
He said their horses were whiter than snow, and their chariot shone.
Diomedes cut off his head. Odysseus took the bow and wolf-skin,
and they went through the darkness toward the Thracian tents.
The men lay asleep, each beside his armor. The horses stood tied.
Diomedes killed twelve men; Odysseus dragged the bodies aside.
Rhesus slept last. Diomedes struck him with the sword, and the king died.
They cut the reins and led away the famous horses. Athena warned them:
“Do not linger. You have done enough. Return before another god wakes them.”

They drove the horses across the field and reached the Achaean camp.
The chiefs welcomed them, but Nestor asked what they had found.
Diomedes told the story. They thanked Athena, and the men slept again,
though the night had changed the fortunes of the army.

Source range: Book 10. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK II

First-pass working translation

Dawn spread her light over the mountains, and Zeus sent Strife among the ships, carrying war in both hands. Agamemnon armed himself in bronze that flashed like fire. He went first into battle, and the Achaeans followed. The Trojans met them beneath the wall. Agamemnon struck Bienor and Oileus, then Isus and Antiphus. He killed Pisander and Hippolochus, sons of Antimachus, whose father had refused to return Menelaus' wife. He stripped their armor, and the Trojans fled before the king's force. Hector did not yet enter the fight. Zeus told Iris: "Go to him, and say that he must remain until Agamemnon is wounded. Then the battle will turn, and Hector may drive the Achaeans back." Agamemnon continued. He killed many men, but at last Coon, son of Antenor, wounded him in the arm and dragged his brother away. Agamemnon killed Coon, yet the wound weakened him. He climbed into his chariot and left the field. Hector saw him go, and advanced. The battle broke over the Achaeans. Hector drove them toward the wall. Diomedes struck Agastrophus, but Paris wounded him in the foot with an arrow. Diomedes cried to Odysseus, and they stood together. Odysseus was left alone when the men around him fell. He fought until Socus pierced his shield and tore his side. Odysseus killed Socus, but blood ran down his body. He called for help, and the Ajaxes came. Nestor carried Machaon away from the battle. Achilles saw the chariot and sent Patroclus to ask who was wounded. Nestor said: "Machaon is hurt. Bring him to your tent, and let the healer tend him. The army is collapsing. Achilles remains apart, though we need him. Perhaps you could persuade him to return, or enter the fight yourself wearing his armor, so the Trojans may fear the sight." Patroclus ran back. He passed the wounded Eurypylus, who begged: "Take me to your tent. Draw the arrow from my thigh, wash the blood, and bind me with medicine. I learned from Achilles how to heal." Patroclus obeyed, while Hector drove the Argives to their ships. The dust rose, and the sea shone behind the fleeing men. The wounded commanders gathered in their shelters: Agamemnon,

Diomedes, and Odysseus. They were unable to fight, but still gave counsel.

Agamemnon said: “Our wall has not held. The ships are in danger.

Call Achilles, if he will listen.”

The Achaeans formed again by the ditch. Ajax held the front,

while Hector sought a way through. Zeus watched from Ida,

and sent terror into the hearts of the Argives.

Patroclus returned to Achilles' tent. He found Eurypylus bleeding,

and cut out the arrow, washed the wound with warm water,

and laid bitter herbs upon it. The herbs stopped the blood,

but Eurypylus' pain did not cease.

Achilles saw Patroclus' tears and asked: “Why do you weep?

You look like a girl running beside her mother, begging to be held.

Do not hide it. Tell me what the army suffers.”

Patroclus answered: “Achilles, you have a cruel heart. The wounded

fill the ships. Agamemnon, Diomedes, and Odysseus cannot fight.

Machaon is hurt, and Eurypylus lies bleeding here. I wish you would

return. If not, let me wear your armor, and lead the Myrmidons.

The Trojans may mistake me for you, and the army may breathe again.”

Achilles replied: “I am not yet ready to forgive Agamemnon.

But take the armor, and lead the men only as far as the ships.

Do not pursue the Trojans to the wall. If you go farther,

you will win me honor but bring death upon yourself.”

He watched the battle through the tent's opening. The armor lay ready,

and Patroclus' request began to move the story toward its catastrophe.

Source range: Book 11. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 12

First-pass working translation

While Patroclus was tending the wounded, Hector led the Trojans against the wall. It had been built to protect the ships, but the gods had not ordained that it endure forever. Polydamas spoke: "Hector, our horses cannot cross the trench. It is deep and sharp with stakes. Let us leave the chariots behind, and send the footmen forward in close ranks. If we scatter, the Achaeans will cut us down." Hector agreed, and ordered the chariots to remain. Five companies moved toward the wall. As a lion enters a fold and the shepherds flee, so the Trojans came on, each man trusting the strength of his neighbor. At the wall, Sarpedon urged Glaucus: "Why do they honor us in Lycia? Why do we receive the best portions and the full cups of wine? Because we must stand in the foremost ranks. Let us show our people that their kings are not only great in name." They advanced. Sarpedon tore away the battlement stone; the wall opened before him. Glaucus was wounded in the arm, but Apollo eased the pain when he prayed. The Lycian ranks followed. Ajax and Teucer defended the gate. Ajax called to his brother: "Hold the bow and shoot the captains. I will carry the shield. If the Trojans reach the ships, our return is gone." Teucer shot Cleobulus and Lycophron, then struck Orsilochus. Hector came against him and shattered his bow with a stone. Ajax covered Teucer as the brothers withdrew. The Trojan companies pressed at the wall. As a woodcutter's axe cuts through an oak, so a great stone broke the battlement. The Greeks defended every opening, but the Trojans climbed. Polydamas saw a hawk carrying a serpent. The snake twisted and struck the bird; blood fell from the hawk's breast, and it dropped the serpent among the warriors. Polydamas said: "This is a sign. We may enter the wall, but we will not leave safely. The snake will make us suffer, even if the hawk carries us forward." Hector answered: "You are always afraid of omens. One sign is not the will of Zeus. I know what I must do. Follow me, and do not delay."

Hector lifted a massive boulder. Two men could scarcely carry it, but he raised it alone, and hurled it at the gate. The hinges broke. The doors swung inward, and the Trojans entered like a storm. The Achaeans fled from the wall. Hector shouted to the Trojans: “Bring fire to the ships. We have reached the first defense. Now the Argives must choose between the sea and the spear.” The dust rose around the broken gate. The wall that had promised protection became a passage for the enemy. The Achaeans held at the ships, and Hector’s voice carried toward the sea.

Source range: Book 12. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 13

First-pass working translation

When Zeus turned his eyes toward Troy, Poseidon saw the Achaeans driven hard against the ships. He pitied them, and went from Samothrace to the plain, taking the form of Calchas. He moved among the leaders, calling them to stand: "The wall has fallen, but the army has not. Hold the line at the ships, and the Trojans will not break you." Ajax answered first, and Idomeneus joined him. Meriones brought men from Crete. The two Ajaxes held the foremost place, like two boars turning upon hounds. They drove back the Trojans and recovered bodies. Hector came against them, leading the ranks. Deiphobus cast his spear at Idomeneus, but missed and killed Ascalaphus. Idomeneus killed Deiphobus' charioteer. The armies closed around the dead. Meriones struck Acamas. Idomeneus killed Othryoneus, who had promised to drive the Achaeans away and marry Cassandra without a bride-price. Idomeneus mocked him: "Let the ground be your wedding bed." The battle spread. Antilochus killed the son of Hicetaon; Hector killed a companion of Ajax. Aeneas and Idomeneus met like lions over a carcass. Neither yielded, and the dust rose between them. Poseidon moved through the Achaean ranks in secret. He touched the hearts of the leaders, reminding each man of his courage. The Argives returned to the fight. They stood around the ships in a wall of shields. Hector urged the Trojans: "Do not scatter. Break the ranks at the ships. If one man falls, another must stand over him. Zeus has promised us victory." Polydamas warned him: "The lines are confused. Call the leaders together, and do not drive the men beyond their strength." Hector answered: "You always counsel delay. The time for words has passed." The Trojans struck the Achaean shields. Ajax killed Caletor; Hector threw a stone and broke the spear of Ajax. The Trojans pressed, but Ajax shouted: "Friends, remember your fathers. If we flee, the ships will burn, and our children will have no home." The Achaeans tightened their line. As a wall stands before the sea, so the shield-wall stood. The spear points flashed, and men fell between the benches of the ships. The battle moved from open ground into the narrow place where a ship's hull became a soldier's shelter.

Hector and Ajax met again. Hector struck Ajax's shield; Ajax struck Hector's breastplate. They separated, but the struggle did not end. Zeus kept his mind on Hector, and Poseidon strengthened the Argives. The Trojans drew back briefly. The Achaeans carried their dead away. But Hector gathered the men, and the fighting returned before the ships. The sea thundered behind the line, and the Achaeans fought as men who have nowhere left to retreat.

Source range: Book 13. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 14

First-pass working translation

Nestor came from the battle, carrying the wounded Machaon.
He met Diomedes and Odysseus, and told them the ships were threatened.
Agamemnon said: “Our wall has failed. We must launch and flee.”
Odysseus rebuked him: “Your mind is broken by fear. Do not send
the army to the sea. Stand among them, and we may still prevail.”
Agamemnon took heart, and the three went back toward the fight.
Hera saw Zeus watching the field from Ida. She desired to distract him,
that Poseidon might aid the Achaeans. She went to Aphrodite:
“Give me the girdle of desire, where every charm is woven—love,
longing, and speech that makes the hardest heart yield.”
Aphrodite gave it. Hera visited Sleep and promised him a golden throne
if he would cast Zeus into slumber. He feared the god's anger,
but accepted. Hera crossed to Ida, perfumed and crowned, and Zeus saw her.
He asked: “Why have you come? You have never looked more beautiful.
Desire has seized me more strongly than in the first hour we loved.”
She answered: “I am going to Oceanus, to visit the parents who raised me.
You are free to sleep beside me if you wish.”
Zeus embraced her. Golden cloud covered them, and the earth bloomed.
Sleep stood behind him and touched his eyes. Zeus slept deeply.
Poseidon entered the Achaean ranks. He cried: “Now is the hour.
The Argives have not forgotten courage. Let every man hold his place.”
The Trojans fell back. Ajax struck Hector with a stone in the chest.
Hector fell, gasping, and the Trojans carried him away.
The Achaeans surged like a wave. Ajax called: “Bring fire to the ships?
No—let the Trojans meet us at the wall they broke.” The Trojans turned,
and many died beneath the spear. Hector lay outside the battle,
breathing hard while the lines moved around him.
Apollo came to him, and gave him strength. He cried:
“Rise. Zeus has not abandoned Troy.” He drove terror into the Argives,
and the Trojans returned. Ajax and Hector met again, but the god's aid
made Hector terrible. The Achaeans gave ground toward the sea.
Zeus woke. He saw the Trojans driven back and knew Hera's deceit.
He called Iris: “Go to Poseidon. Tell him to leave the battle.”

Tell Apollo to strengthen Hector. The day will belong to Troy.”

Poseidon answered Iris: “Zeus is not my master alone. The three brothers share the world. Yet he is older, and I will not throw heaven into war.”

He withdrew to the sea, angry but obedient.

Apollo entered the fight openly. He carried the aegis, and the Achaeans shrank before it. Hector raised his spear and broke the wall's gate.

The Trojans poured through. The ships stood exposed, and fire was near.

Source range: Book 14. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 15

First-pass working translation

Zeus woke on Ida and saw the Trojans pressed toward the ships.
He understood Hera's deception. He spoke to her in anger:
"You have done this, and Poseidon has entered the battle.
But the hour has come for the Argives to suffer. Send Iris to him;
let Apollo restore Hector's courage and drive the army forward.
The Trojans will reach the ships, and Patroclus will be moved to act."
Hera descended from Ida and returned to Olympus. Zeus sent Iris
to the sea. Poseidon answered: "I will not resist the elder's will.
But remember: we share the world, and my anger will remain."
Apollo found Hector beyond the battle, still weak from Ajax's blow.
He stood before him and covered him with a mist. Hector rose,
and Apollo gave him the aegis. The Achaeans saw it and fled.
Apollo struck down the wall before Hector. The stones fell,
and the Trojans poured through. Hector called to the men:
"Let the ships be our prize. Bring fire; do not stop for armor.
If one man turns aside, let the next kill him."
Ajax stood upon the deck of a ship, calling to the Achaeans:
"Do not retreat. Keep the fire from the vessels. Hector is strong,
but we are many. Stand with me." He struck the Trojans with a pole,
and the ship's deck became a fortress.
Hector seized a stone and shattered the gates of a ship. The Trojans
carried torches. The Argives defended the hulls with spears and axes.
Ajax killed many men, but Hector kept coming like a storm.
The fire reached the ship of Protesilaus. Hector threw a torch
upon the stern, and the flame ran through the dry timbers.
Patroclus saw it from Achilles' tent, and struck his thigh:
"Achilles, the ships are burning. If we wait, we will have no camp.
Let me take the Myrmidons. Give me your armor, so the Trojans
will think you have returned. I will drive them from the ships,
but I will obey your command and not approach the city."
Achilles answered: "Go. The army needs you. Tell the men to fight.
I will pray for your return. Do not chase them beyond the wall."
Patroclus armed the Myrmidons. He gave his father's armor to the heralds,

and they carried it out. The men looked upon it and rejoiced.
The horses stamped, and the troops formed beneath the borrowed sign.
Hector and Ajax fought around the burning ship. The Trojans shouted,
but the sight of Achilles' armor turned their hearts. They believed
the terrible man had entered the battle again. The Achaeans advanced.
The fire was beaten down. Hector's courage faltered, but he called
the Trojans to follow. Patroclus drove them from the ships,
and the battle rolled across the plain. The day had turned,
but the fate of the borrowed armor was already moving toward death.

Source range: Book 15. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 16

First-pass working translation

Patroclus came to Achilles in tears. “You are like a father who refuses his child. Let me wear your armor. The Trojans will think you have returned, and the Achaeans will breathe. I will drive them from the ships, but I will not approach the wall.”

Achilles answered: “I do not refuse you from anger. Take the armor, and take the Myrmidons. When the fire is gone from the ships, return. Do not chase glory beyond what I have commanded.”

He armed Patroclus in the shining armor. The horses stamped; Automedon took the reins. Achilles stood before the troops:

“Remember your strength. Do not fight like children. Patroclus will lead. When the Trojans see this armor, they will flee from the ships.”

Patroclus prayed to Zeus, and the Myrmidons came out like wolves.

Achilles watched them march, wishing the gods would grant their return.

Patroclus drove toward the ships. The Trojans saw Achilles' armor and fell back. The fire was beaten down. Ajax and his men rejoiced.

Patroclus killed Pyraechmes and drove the Trojans from the hulls.

Apollo warned Hector: “Do not meet Patroclus yet. The hour is not ready.”

Hector left the battle, but the Trojan ranks broke. Sarpedon saw them flee and called Glaucus: “We must stand for Lycia. Let us defend our people.”

Patroclus and Sarpedon met. Sarpedon threw first and missed;

Patroclus struck Thrasymelus, his companion. Sarpedon cast again, but Patroclus pierced him beneath the ribs. He fell like an oak.

He called to Glaucus: “Do not leave me. Call the Lycians to defend my body. If they strip my armor, the disgrace will be greater than death.”

Glaucus prayed to Apollo, and the god healed his wound. He rallied the Lycians, while Zeus looked at his son and considered saving him.

Hera warned Zeus: “If you rescue Sarpedon, the other gods will demand the same. Let his fate stand. Send Sleep and Death to carry him home.”

Zeus sent Apollo. The god washed Sarpedon and gave him to the twins, who bore him to Lycia. The armies fought over his armor.

Patroclus drove the Trojans toward the city. Achilles' warning faded behind the noise of battle. He killed Cebriones, Hector's charioteer, and mocked Hector over the body. Hector seized a spear, but Patroclus

escaped the throw. They fought like fire and wind.
Apollo struck Patroclus from behind, knocked away his helmet,
and broke the spear in his hands. Euphorbus wounded him;
Hector came and drove the final spear beneath his belly.
Patroclus said: "Hector, you are proud of my death. But Achilles
will kill you. He is near, and your day is short."
Hector answered: "You are no longer protected by Achilles. He is far away,
and I have taken your life." He stripped the armor from Patroclus.
Patroclus fell. The Achaeans and Trojans fought over his body.
Menelaus stood first, killing Euphorbus. Hector wore Achilles' armor,
but Zeus had already marked the day when it would betray him.

Source range: Book 16. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 17

First-pass working translation

Menelaus stood over Patroclus and killed Euphorbus,
the first man to wound him. He stripped the bright armor,
but Hector saw him and came across the field. Menelaus withdrew,
calling Ajax to guard the body. The Trojans and Achaeans closed around it.
Hector wore Achilles' armor, shining like a star. He drove toward
Patroclus, wanting both the body and the name that came with the armor.
Ajax cried to Menelaus: "Stand beside me. We must not let the Trojans
carry him away. The dead man is our friend, and his body is our shame."
The battle became a storm around Patroclus. Hector seized the horses,
but Automedon drove them away. The Achaeans dragged the body backward;
the Trojans pulled it forward. Neither side could gain ground.
Glaucus rebuked Hector: "You have forgotten Sarpedon.
We guarded his body, but you wear the armor of Achilles
and leave Patroclus for others. Call the Trojans back."
Hector answered: "Do not accuse me. I will take the body,
and Zeus may grant me strength." He called Aeneas and the sons of Priam.
The Achaeans defended the corpse. Menelaus sent Antilochus to tell
Achilles that Patroclus had fallen. Ajax and Meriones lifted the body;
Ajax carried the weight on his shoulders while Meriones fought behind.
Hector rushed them. Ajax turned, and Hector retreated. The dust rose,
and Zeus darkened the day. The Trojans saw Patroclus almost within reach.
Automedon could not control the horses, which had belonged to Achilles.
They stood still, grieving for Patroclus. Zeus considered giving them
to Hector, but Hera held them back. Automedon called Alcimedon,
who mounted beside him. They returned to battle.
Hector pursued them and tried to seize the chariot. Automedon killed
Hector's companion, and the Trojans drew back. The Achaeans renewed
their defense of the body.
Apollo entered the fight, wearing the shape of a warrior. He struck
Menelaus, then urged Hector onward. The Trojans came like a dark wave.
Ajax and Menelaus stood together, but the gods turned the balance.
Menelaus sent Antilochus again to Achilles. Antilochus ran through
the ranks and cried: "Patroclus is dead. Hector wears your armor."

The Trojans fight for the body. Come, or we cannot hold him.”
Achilles' horses mourned. Thetis had given them to her son,
and they knew the death that had come beneath borrowed arms.
Zeus spoke to them: “Why did I give you to a mortal king?
No horse is more sorrowful than you. The man you carried is gone.”
He made them swift again. They carried Automedon and the chariot
back to the fight, while Zeus sent a cloud over the battlefield.
Night approached, but the struggle did not cease. The Trojans pulled
at Patroclus, and the Achaeans resisted. The body was like a wall
between the armies, and every man who touched it entered the war's center.
At last the Achaeans carried Patroclus from the field.
Hector and the Trojans kept Achilles' armor, believing victory had come.
But the armor was not a man, and its brightness would not save Hector
when Achilles returned.

Source range: Book 17. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 18

First-pass working translation

Antilochus came to Achilles and told him that Patroclus was dead. Achilles' knees failed. He seized dust in both hands and poured it over his head. His dark hair was soiled, and he lay upon the ground, tearing his face. His mother had once given him that hair for the river; now he offered it to Patroclus.

Thetis heard him beneath the sea and came with her sisters.

Achilles said: "Mother, Patroclus is dead. Hector wears my armor.

I was not there. I sent him out, and he will never return.

I have no reason to live if I cannot punish Hector."

Thetis answered: "You know what follows. If you kill Hector, your own death will come soon after. Stay, and you may live."

Achilles replied: "Let it come. I cannot remain while my friend lies unburied. I will go now, though I have no armor. Perhaps the sight of me will make the Trojans release the body."

The Achaeans mourned Patroclus. Iris came from Hera and told Achilles:

"Do not enter the battle unarmed. Athena will cover you with fire.

Stand by the trench and show yourself."

Achilles went to the wall. Athena set a golden cloud around his head and made a flame rise from him. He cried three times. The Trojans heard and terror seized them; horses broke their lines, and the dead were left.

The Achaeans recovered Patroclus' body and carried him to the tent.

Hector called a council. Polydamas said: "Let us return to Troy.

Achilles will enter the battle. We cannot stand before him."

Hector answered: "You counsel fear. We will remain in the field."

The Trojans ate and kept watch. The Achaeans gathered around Patroclus.

Achilles ordered that no one wash his body yet. He cut the throat of a bull and placed the dead man's hair upon the bier. He promised Patroclus:

"I will not bury you until I bring Hector's head and armor here."

Thetis went to Olympus and asked Hephaestus to make new armor.

He forged a shield vast as the moon, and upon it placed the earth, the sea, the sky, the sun, moon, and all the stars.

He made two cities. In one, weddings and dances filled the streets; flutes sounded, and torches led the brides from their chambers.

But outside the walls two men disputed a blood-price. Elders sat
 upon polished stones, and a herald held the scepter as each spoke.
 In the other city an army lay in ambush. The attackers drove cattle
 from the fields; shepherds and dogs defended them. War broke out
 beside the river, and a dark fate stood over the men.
 He made a fallow field, rich and dark, where plowmen turned the earth.
 They looked back as they reached the boundary, and a steward gave them wine.
 He made a king's estate where reapers cut the wheat; young men bound it,
 and a woman served them food beneath an oak.
 He made a vineyard heavy with grapes. Boys carried baskets;
 a child played a lyre, and the harvesters sang. He made a herd of cattle,
 with a bull leading them. Lions attacked; dogs and herdsmen pursued,
 but the lions tore the bull and drank its blood.
 He made a sheepfold in a beautiful valley. He made a dancing floor,
 where youths and maidens moved in circles, and the people watched.
 Around the rim he set Oceanus, the river that encircles the world.
 He gave the armor to Thetis. She descended like a hawk and brought it
 to Achilles. The bronze shone before the Achaeans. All feared its beauty.
 Achilles called an assembly: "Agamemnon, let our anger end.
 Briseis and the gifts may return. I thought only of Patroclus.
 Now my heart is set upon battle."
 Agamemnon answered: "I was blinded. Zeus and Delusion deceived me.
 Let the gifts be brought. Briseis is untouched. I swear it."
 The gifts came, and Briseis saw Patroclus on the bier. She wept:
 "You were kind to me when Achilles took me from my city.
 You promised that I would become his wife. Now both hope and kindness
 are gone." The women mourned with her.
 Achilles would not eat. Zeus sent Athena to fill his heart with nectar,
 so hunger would not weaken him. He mounted his chariot and called:
 "Xanthus and Balius, bring me back from battle. Do not leave me there
 as you left Patroclus." The immortal horse answered:
 "We will carry you, but a god and fate will kill you."
 Achilles entered the field, wearing the armor that would lead him
 to Hector and then to his own appointed death.

Source range: Book 18. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 19

First-pass working translation

Dawn rose from the sea, and Achilles called the Achaeans to assembly.
He stood beside the ships and said: “Let our anger end. Agamemnon,
return Briseis. The dead have made all private quarrels small.”
Agamemnon answered: “I was blinded by Ate, the power that misleads.
Zeus himself has been deceived by her. I will return the girl,
and give the gifts promised before. Let the heralds bring them.”
The gifts came: tripods, gold, cauldrons, cities' treasure,
and Briseis. She entered Achilles' tent and saw Patroclus dead.
She wept: “You were kind to me, though Achilles took me from my home.
I thought I would become his wife. Now I mourn you, and the man who fell.”
Achilles did not eat. He looked toward the battle and said:
“Patroclus, you will not go unavenged. Hector's life will pay for yours.”
Zeus sent Athena to strengthen him with nectar and ambrosia,
so hunger would not weaken his limbs. The army armed itself.
Menelaus asked whether the Achaeans should eat before battle.
Achilles answered: “No food can enter me while my friend lies dead.
Let the others eat. I will fight until Hector falls.”
Agamemnon and Achilles stood before the people. They clasped hands,
but did not embrace. Agamemnon swore Briseis remained untouched.
The army returned to its ranks, eager for the field.
Achilles put on the armor Hephaestus had made. The greaves clasped
his legs; the corselet covered his chest; the helmet shone like a star.
He lifted the shield whose surface held the whole world.
His horses trembled. Achilles spoke to them: “Do not leave me dead
as you left Patroclus.” The horse Xanthus answered in human speech:
“We will carry you swiftly, but a god and fate will take your life.
It is not our fault; the deathless power will bring you down.”
Achilles replied: “I know. I will not turn back. Let us meet Hector.”
He drove into the battle, and the Achaeans followed him.

Source range: Book 19. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 20

First-pass working translation

Zeus called the gods to council. “The mortal Achilles has entered battle.
If he meets Hector, Troy will fall before its time. Let each god choose
his side. We will not hold back any longer.”

The gods descended. Apollo stood beside the Trojans; Athena beside the Greeks.
Poseidon, Hera, Hermes, and Hephaestus gathered around the Achaeans;
Ares and Aphrodite joined Apollo. The earth shook as they took their places.
Achilles sought Hector, but Apollo hid the Trojan hero in mist.
Aeneas came forward, urged by Apollo. He said: “Why do you threaten me?
We have fought before. I will not retreat.”

Achilles answered: “Do not stand against me. I have no mercy today.
Patroclus has fallen, and I will not let you escape.”

Aeneas cast his spear. Achilles' shield stopped it. Achilles threw,
but Poseidon carried the spear away and saved Aeneas, for his fate was
not to die there. Aeneas struck a stone, and Achilles rushed toward him.
Poseidon lifted Aeneas from the field, and the two heroes were separated.
Achilles killed many Trojans. Apollo stirred them forward, but the men
could not remain before him. Hector alone held his ground until Apollo
called him away. The battle rolled toward the river.

The gods contended among themselves, while the mortals fought below.
Athena challenged Ares, and Hera restrained Aphrodite. Hermes avoided
Poseidon, saying: “I will not fight the lord of the sea.” Hephaestus
faced the river, and fire answered water.

Achilles met Polydorus, Priam's youngest son, who ran swiftly before him.
Achilles pierced him from behind. Hector saw his brother fall and came
against Achilles. He threw, but Athena blew the spear back to him.
Achilles cast again. Hector vanished beneath Apollo's cloud.

Achilles turned to kill more men, but Hector was already carried away.

The river ran red, and the Trojan army fled toward the gates.

Source range: Book 20. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 21

First-pass working translation

Achilles drove the Trojans toward the river Scamander. He cut their ranks like a fire through reeds. Twelve young men he took alive from the river, to pay for Patroclus at the pyre. He bound them and sent them back. Lycaon's son met him, the man Achilles had once captured and sold. Lycaon begged: "Do not kill me. I am not the son of Hector's mother. I have returned from Lemnos only twelve days ago. A man is not made twice; you killed me once and now my fate has brought me back." Achilles answered: "Do not speak of mercy. Patroclus is dead. You too must die. My own death is near. No man can turn it away." He struck Lycaon and cast him into the river. Asteropaeus came from the Paeonians, born beside the Axios. He threw two spears, but Achilles wounded his arm and took his life. Achilles stripped him, while the river carried the body downstream. Scamander spoke in anger: "Achilles, you have filled my waters with corpses. Leave the banks. Kill men upon the plain, not within my stream." Achilles answered: "I will not stop until Hector falls." The river rose against him. It covered the plain and swept dead men through its channels. Achilles was thrown from his feet. He climbed an elm, but the tree fell; he swam and called to Zeus: "No god has suffered as I do. If the river kills me, I will have died without honor. Better a man kill me than water carry me nameless." Hera heard him and sent Hephaestus. Fire spread along the bank. It dried the bodies and burned the reeds. Scamander cried: "Stop, Hephaestus. I will no longer oppose Achilles." The fire and river ceased. The gods fought among themselves. Athena struck Ares; Hera mocked Artemis and seized her bow; Hermes refused to fight Leto. Poseidon and Apollo held back, waiting for the day when Troy's fate could no longer be deferred. Achilles returned to the plain. Hector alone remained before the gates. The Trojans fled into the city. Agenor stood, but Apollo hid him and drew Achilles away. Achilles chased a phantom of Agenor, while the army passed through the wall. Apollo revealed himself and said: "Why pursue a god? The day of Hector

has not yet come.” Achilles answered: “You have cheated me again,
but I will take vengeance on the Trojans when I return.”

He went toward the city, and the gods withdrew from the field.

Scamander ran clean again, but the dead remained along his banks.

Source range: Book 21. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 22

First-pass working translation

The Trojans fled into the city. Hector remained outside the gates.
Priam saw Achilles approaching and called:
“Come inside, my child. Do not stand alone before him. He is stronger.
You will leave me without a son, and the city will fall. I have lost
many sons already. Do not make your father and mother mourn you.”
Hecuba tore her robe and cried: “Have pity. Come behind the wall.
Achilles killed your brothers and will not spare you.”
Hector would not enter. Shame held him there. He had sent the army out;
he could not hide while others died. Yet he thought of approaching Achilles
with gifts: Helen and her wealth, and half the city's treasure.
Achilles came. Hector fled. They ran around Troy's walls three times,
like two men racing for a prize. The gods watched. Zeus lifted the scales;
Hector's fate sank. Athena came beside Achilles, wearing Deiphobus' form.
Hector stopped and said to Achilles: “I will no longer flee.
Let us fight. If I kill you, I will return your armor, but not your body.
If you kill me, return my body to Troy.”
Achilles answered: “Do not speak of oaths. There can be no friendship
between lion and man, nor between wolves and sheep. You killed Patroclus.
No ransom will save you.”
Hector cast his spear. Athena turned it aside. He called Deiphobus,
but the brother had vanished. Hector knew the gods had deceived him.
He drew his sword and rushed forward.
Achilles watched the armor, seeking the place where Hector could die.
Hector struck, but the spear glanced from the shield. Achilles' spear
entered Hector's throat. He fell in the dust.
Hector said: “I beg you by your life and parents: return my body.
Let my father and mother ransom me. Do not give me to the dogs.”
Achilles answered: “Do not ask. I wish I could cut your flesh and eat it.
No man can keep the dogs from you. Your body will lie beside Patroclus.”
Hector's spirit left him. Achilles stripped the armor. The Achaeans came,
and each struck the dead man. Achilles pierced the feet, tied them to his
chariot, and dragged Hector behind the horses. The dust rose over his head.
Andromache heard the cries from the wall. She ran out and saw her husband

dragged beneath the chariot. Her knees failed. She tore her veil and said:
“Hector, you have died and left us. Our child will have no protector.
The city will be destroyed, and the women carried away. I too will go,
and my son will be taken from me. You were father and husband to me.”
Hecuba and Helen mourned. Helen said: “You alone were kind to me.
Your brothers and sisters hated me, but you defended me. Now I hear
your death and know there is no friend left in Troy.”
Priam and Hecuba tried to stop the people from leaving the gates,
for Achilles' anger still moved around the corpse. The Achaeans returned
to the ships, while Hector's body lay in the dust beneath the wall.

Source range: Book 22. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 23

First-pass working translation

The Achaeans returned to the ships, but Achilles did not eat.
He remembered Patroclus, and sleep would not come. At dawn he ordered
the men to carry wood and build the pyre. They cut their hair and laid it
upon the body. Achilles placed a lock of his own hair in Patroclus' hands.
He called the winds and prayed for fire. The pyre burned through the night.
Achilles slaughtered sheep, cattle, and horses; he killed twelve Trojan
young men beside the fire. Patroclus' spirit appeared in a dream:
“Do not forget me. Bury me quickly, so I may pass the gates of Hades.
Let our bones lie in one urn, as we grew together in your house.”
Achilles woke and told the men to continue the funeral. They quenched
the fire with wine, gathered the white bones, and placed them in a golden urn.
They raised a mound and marked the place, though a greater tomb would come.
Achilles called the army to games in Patroclus' honor. He brought out
tripods, cauldrons, gold, women, cattle, and iron as prizes.
First came the chariots. Eumelus drove well, but Athena broke his yoke;
Diomedes won, and gave the second prize to Antilochus. Menelaus protested
that Antilochus had cut across him. Antilochus apologized, and Menelaus
returned part of the prize, honoring both skill and restraint.
Achilles awarded Eumelus a special prize, though he had not finished;
“He would have won if the goddess had not harmed him.”
In the boxing, Epeius defeated Euryalus. Odysseus and Ajax wrestled,
but neither could throw the other. Ajax won the foot race, though Athena
made Odysseus slip in dung. The Achaeans laughed; Achilles still grieved.
Diomedes won the spear contest; Meriones won the archery. Teucer missed
the bird, and Meriones struck it. The final contest was the heavy stone.
Polypoetes threw farthest, and the games ended near sunset.
Achilles gave the prizes, remembering Patroclus as each man competed.
The games made the army's grief public; after them, the men returned
to the ships, while Achilles still watched the tomb.

Source range: Book 23. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.

BOOK 24

First-pass working translation

The games ended, and the Achaeans returned to their ships.
Achilles still dragged Hector behind his chariot, circling Patroclus'
tomb. The gods pitied the dead man. Apollo protected his body,
keeping the dust from his skin and the wounds from decay.
The immortals argued. Hera and Athena would not forgive Troy,
but Zeus said: "The gods honor Hector, and his family will ransom him.
Send Thetis to Achilles, and Iris to Priam."
Iris went to the old king: "Go to Achilles' tent. Take gifts,
and clasp his knees. He will remember his own father. Go alone,
with one herald and a wagon. Do not fear."
Priam entered his house and called his sons. He ordered a wagon,
and loaded it with robes, gold, tripods, and a mixing bowl.
He prepared twelve garments for Hector, and gifts for Achilles.
Hecuba begged him not to go. Priam answered:
"I will go. If Zeus has sent the sign, I will trust it.
I cannot lie in this house while my son remains unburied."
Hermes came in the shape of a young man and guided Priam through
the Achaean camp. He put the guards to sleep and led the wagon
past the trenches. They reached Achilles' shelter unseen.
Priam entered and clasped Achilles' knees. He kissed the hands
that had killed his sons, and said:
"Remember your father, Achilles, like me an old man near death.
He too may hear that enemies surround him, and no one protects him.
But I am more pitiful: I have done what no other mortal has done.
I have brought my lips to the hands of the man who killed my child.
Give me Hector. Let me take him home. Accept the ransom.
You too have a father. If he lives, his heart rejoices in you.
I have no Hector. He was my only protector, and you have killed him."
Achilles looked at the old man and thought of Peleus. He wept;
Priam wept for Hector, while Achilles remembered Patroclus.
The tent filled with grief shared by enemies.
Achilles said: "You have come bravely. No man could have entered.
Let us not provoke one another. The gods have given you Hector's body.

Take him. You have moved my heart.”

He raised Hector from the bier and placed him upon the wagon.

The women in the tent washed him and wrapped him in clean cloth,
so that Achilles would not see the wounds he had made.

Achilles asked: “How many days do you need to bury him?”

Priam answered: “Nine days to mourn, on the tenth to burn him,
on the eleventh to raise the mound, and on the twelfth to fight again.”

Achilles granted the truce.

Priam slept in the shelter, but Hermes woke him before dawn:

“Rise. If Agamemnon sees you, he will demand to know why you remain.”

Priam loaded Hector and left. Achilles watched in silence.

At Troy, Cassandra saw the wagon and cried from the wall:

“Here comes Hector, carried home. Come out and mourn him.”

The people gathered. Andromache held his head and lamented:

“Hector, you have died young, and left your wife and child. The city will fall.”

Hecuba mourned her son, and Helen spoke:

“You alone were kind to me. The others looked at me with hatred.

Now I have no friend left in Troy.”

They built the pyre, brought wood, and burned Hector. At dawn
they gathered the bones, wrapped them in purple, and placed them
in a golden chest. They raised a mound. The people returned to Troy,
still grieving, while the poem's anger came to rest beside the dead.

Source range: Book 24. Full-book provisional draft. Not approved for final layout.